



HANGZHOU NORMAL UNIVERSITY

# UNDERGRADUATE GRADUATION THESIS

(Class of 2022)

|                    |                                                                                                                     |          |                     |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|---------------------|
| TITLE              | <b>The Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception<br/>— Evidence from the International Apparel Industry</b> |          |                     |
| SCHOOL             | Alibaba Business School                                                                                             |          |                     |
| MAJOR              | International Business                                                                                              |          |                     |
| CLASS              | International Business 182                                                                                          |          |                     |
| STUDENT            | Keman Xiang                                                                                                         | STUDENT  |                     |
|                    |                                                                                                                     | ID       | 2018211903038       |
| SUPERVISOR         | Fengjun Zhao                                                                                                        | ACADEMIC |                     |
|                    |                                                                                                                     | TITLE    | Associate Professor |
| COMPLETION<br>DATE | April 5, 2022                                                                                                       |          |                     |
| DEFENSE DATE       | April 13, 2022                                                                                                      |          |                     |
| GRADE              | Good                                                                                                                |          |                     |

# AUTHOR'S NOTE FOR PhD APPLICATION PORTFOLIO

## Research Context

This English-language portfolio edition preserves my **2022 undergraduate thesis**, **The Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception: Evidence from the International Apparel Industry**. Completed during my undergraduate study in **International Business**, the project represents an early stage of my development as an **empirical business researcher**, spanning literature synthesis, research-question formulation, construct operationalization, secondary-data collection, **quantitative analysis**, **hypothesis testing**, and interpretation.

## Academic Supervision

The thesis was completed under the supervision of **Fengjun Zhao** (赵奉军), Associate Professor at Alibaba Business School, Hangzhou Normal University. Professor Zhao received a bachelor's degree in Economics from **Wuhan University**, a master's degree in Economics from **Fudan University**, and a Ph.D. in Economics from **Nanjing University**. His research has focused on urban and real-estate economics, housing policy, and Chinese economic development, with research affiliations at Fudan University and Nanjing University and an extensive record of empirical economic research. His supervision provided the academic setting in which this undergraduate research was developed and completed.

## Research and Analytical Content

The thesis examines **relationships between brand management and consumer perception in the international apparel industry**. Brand Management was operationalized through **Brand Positioning**, **Brand Image**, **Brand Extension**, and **Brand Marketing**, and the project combined **Excel-based data preparation and measurement** with **Stata regression analysis**. For this portfolio edition, I reconstructed the Stata workflow from the original analytical datasets and successfully reproduced the six regression models reported in the study, creating a transparent companion reproducibility archive.

## Retrospective Perspective

I present this thesis as an **archival** research artifact rather than as a study retrospectively redesigned to reflect my current methodological training. From my present perspective as a PhD applicant, I recognize opportunities to strengthen the original work in sample design, construct measurement, model specification, robustness assessment, reproducible workflows, and the distinction between statistical association and causal inference. I have therefore **preserved the historical analysis** while documenting its reproducibility and limitations. This retrospective process reflects the progression of my research interests toward more rigorous quantitative and data-analytic approaches to business research.

Source note: Professor Zhao's academic background is based on his Hangzhou Normal University faculty profile. This Author's Note was added in 2026 for the PhD application portfolio and was not part of the original 2022 thesis.



HANGZHOU NORMAL UNIVERSITY

## ACADEMIC INTEGRITY DECLARATION

I, Keman Xiang, am a student in Class 182 of International Business, majoring in International Business at Alibaba Business School, Hangzhou Normal University. Student ID: 2018211903038.

I solemnly declare that the undergraduate thesis entitled “The Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception: Evidence from the International Apparel Industry” is the result of my own research. The data sources are authentic and reliable, and the work contains no plagiarism. If any violation of academic research integrity is found, I am willing to bear all resulting consequences.

Declarant: Keman Xiang

April 5, 2022

## The Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception — Evidence from the International Apparel Industry

Major: International Business 182  
Supervisor: Fengjun Zhao

Student: Keman Xiang

**Abstract:** Using the five major domestic and international schools of thought on the factors through which brand management affects consumer perception as the main logical framework, this review presents and evaluates the research achievements of representative scholars in the sequence of major theories and historical milestones. It then discusses development trends, draws on prior research experience, and seeks to establish a relevant foundation for subsequent research.

**Keywords:** five major schools of thought; domestic and international research; representative theories and scholars; evaluation of strengths and weaknesses; development trends

## **I. Literature Review**

### **1 Introduction**

As an important field of management research, brand management has consistently attracted academic attention. In terms of time, over its 90-year development history from the 1930s to the present, brand management has accumulated a substantial research history and industry foundation. In terms of breadth, branches of brand management research have flourished, forming five major schools of thought and more than twenty categories of theories, while integrating across disciplines such as psychology, consumer behavior, journalism and communication, and design. In terms of depth, brand management, as one of the three major theoretical research focuses in the history of marketing development, occupies an important position in academic marketing research and, together with relationship marketing and consumer behavior, has been extensively studied by scholars in China and abroad.

In summary, the following review uses the five major domestic and international schools of thought on “the effectiveness of brand management on consumer perception” as its principal logical framework. It presents and evaluates the research achievements of representative scholars in the sequence of important theories and historical milestones, and finally discusses development trends, drawing on previous experience to establish a relevant foundation for subsequent research.

## **2 Domestic and International Research on Brand**

### **Management**

#### **2.1 Review of International Brand Management Research**

##### **2.1.1 Brand Semiotics School — Emphasizing the Influence of Visual Symbols on Consumer Perception**

The brand semiotics school is a traditional school from the early development of brand management. Its primary focus is answering the question, “How do consumers identify

brands?” The following theories are the most influential:

First, Brand Identity theory. Brand identity was a major focus of early brand research, represented primarily by J. N. Kapferer in Europe and David A. Aaker in the United States. Kapferer examined how different means, such as names and symbols, can express the question of “Who am I?” for a brand. Aaker, in *Building Strong Brands* (1996), both agreed with and qualified Kapferer’s view. He argued that (1) firms should give brands unique and explicit meanings, and (2) firms should establish comprehensive brand identity systems rather than relying only on names or symbols. The latter view further developed Kapferer’s position.

The theoretical influence of the brand semiotics school was significant, triggering historical waves of commercial and advertising creative design. CIS (Corporate Identity System) was also once highly popular. However, after the 1990s, this line of research gradually moved from the center to the periphery.

Second, Levy’s brand image theory. S. J. Levy and B. B. Gardner’s 1955 article “The Product and the Brand” initiated a rational understanding of brands and, in particular, creatively proposed the concept of “Brand Image” (BI), regarding it as the key distinction between a brand and a product. “Brand image” was highly significant: it brought imagination and commercial opportunities to markets and promoted the development of advertising, design, and communication industries. It remained active until later research on “brand associations” gradually replaced its importance.

Third, Park’s three-dimensional brand concept, BCM. Because the preceding studies remained relatively limited and did not fully explore the independent value of brands, C. W. Park in the United States was not satisfied with the concept of “brand image.” He argued that there are deeper differences beneath the surface distinction between brands and products and proposed a deeper structure of the brand concept: brands have three dimensions—functional, experiential, and symbolic. The important significance of this theory is that it opened broad space for the development of modern brand management theory, including brand experience and the meaning of brand symbolism or symbols.

Fourth, USP theory, represented by R. Reeves and Bates. In the early 1950s, R. Reeves proposed the traditional USP theory: (1) advertising should communicate a clear consumer benefit proposition, and (2) differentiation is fundamental to every proposition. In the 1990s,

Bates inherited and developed Reeves's theory. The new view held that the creativity of a unique selling proposition lies in revealing the essence of a brand and powerfully demonstrating the brand's uniqueness. Overall, both emphasized the importance of brand uniqueness and promoted the diversification of visual expression.

### **2.1.2 Brand Marketing School — Emphasizing the Influence of Marketing Strategies on Consumer Perception**

The brand marketing school inherited and innovated upon previous research. It recognized the role of visual effects while placing greater emphasis on the important role of marketing:

First, David Ogilvy's brand image theory. Previous research emphasized the visual expression of product differentiation. However, as markets developed and product differences narrowed, distinguishing products through product attributes became increasingly difficult. In the 1950s, David Ogilvy proposed brand image theory, whose core proposition was that creating a brand image attractive to customers is the key, and that advertising, as a long-term investment, plays an important role in shaping brand image.

By comparison, brand image theory developed beyond traditional symbolic perspectives. It regarded brand management not as a single factor but as a systematic undertaking involving products, marketing, services, and other aspects, and held that shaping brand image requires the long-term and persistent efforts of all employees in an enterprise.

Second, positioning theory, represented by Jack Trout and Al Ries. As products became increasingly homogeneous, the preceding brand image theory became less capable of supporting firms in creating product differentiation, and positioning theory emerged. In 1979, Jack Trout and Al Ries first proposed positioning theory in *Positioning*. Its core proposition is to start from the consumer perspective and occupy a favorable position in consumers' minds from the outside in; therefore, consumer research should be used to identify a product's unique market position. Positioning theory has had far-reaching influence and provides strong practical guidance for current brand positioning strategies.

Third, brand personality theory, led by Grey, Saburo Kobayashi, and Jennifer Aaker. In the 1960s, the U.S. advertising company Grey proposed a "brand personality philosophy,"

while Japan's Saburo Kobayashi proposed a "corporate personality theory." Their core views were: (1) among logo, image, and personality, personality is the highest level [20]; (2) brands should be personified; (3) core graphics or thematic copy should be emphasized; and (4) symbols should be emphasized. On this basis, in 1997 Jennifer Aaker established another milestone by deriving the "Big Five Model" of brand personality using empirical methods. This not only made brand personality an important new concept but also provided a basic frame of reference for brand personality.

In terms of significance, on the one hand, brand personality was a deeper development of the preceding research on "brand image." Brand image is external, while brand personality is internal, opening a new direction for brand personification. On the other hand, brand personality laid a foundation for subsequent research on brand relationships.

Fourth, Fournier's consumer-brand relationship theory. In the 1990s, U.S. scholar S. Fournier pioneered the field of consumer-brand relationships, with "Brand Relationship Quality" (BRQ) as the core proposition. Fournier was innovative in several respects: she combined affective and rational approaches; provided a method for measuring consumer-brand relationships; and, unlike the traditional one-way perspective, focused on multilateral interactive relationships. Her consumer-brand relationship model therefore became a theoretical starting point for subsequent research.

Fifth, Muniz's brand community theory. In response to the digital trend of the new century, A. M. Muniz published "Brand Community" in 2001 and advocated the leading role of social media and communities. This theory opened a new direction in consumer-brand relationship research and became a major academic focus, making experience, interaction, sharing, immersion, and brand ecosystems exceptionally active areas of study.

### **2.1.3 Brand Strategy School — Emphasizing the Influence of Systematic Management on Consumer Perception**

The strategy school elevated brand management to a new level by viewing corporate management processes and consumer responses from an overall perspective:

First, the two major theories of brand leadership.

The early corporate brand manager system. In 1931, Neil McElroy of Procter & Gamble

pioneered the brand manager system, arguing that a brand manager should centrally coordinate the management process and bear full responsibility. The brand manager system has both advantages and disadvantages: it is a mature and competitive system, but it is time-consuming and has limited universal applicability.

As the traditional brand management model revealed shortcomings in a changing environment—for example, its inability to handle multiple brands, brand extensions, and sub-brands—Aaker proposed a new theory of brand leadership in *Brand Leadership* [12] in 2000. It differed from the earlier system in several important respects: Aaker emphasized the CEO as the brand manager, whereas the earlier system focused on brand managers; he emphasized strategy, whereas the earlier system was tactically oriented; and he emphasized a broad management scope, whereas the earlier system focused on a limited scope. Overall, Aaker revised the traditional theory in multiple respects.

Second, modern Brand Stewardship and 360-degree brand management theories. In the early 1990s, Ogilvy introduced “Brand Stewardship” [14], which essentially uses comprehensive corporate planning to ensure that brand-related activities reflect the core spirit of the brand. In the mid-1990s, it further proposed “360-degree brand management,” focusing on ensuring complete communication management at every point of contact with consumers. Both theories are proactive and actively reach and manage the relationship between brands and consumers.

Third, integrated marketing and interactive communication theory. Integrated Marketing (IM) was proposed by Tom Duncan and Sandra Moriarty in *Driving Brand Value: Using Integrated Marketing to Manage Profitable Stakeholder Relationships* [15]. In essence, integrated marketing is a business model describing a cross-functional integrated process through which firms create, maintain, and strengthen brand relationships, while also emphasizing communication and interaction in brand relationship networks. Its distinctive significance lies in approaching the issue from the perspective of intangible asset management, unlike traditional research on tangible assets.

Fourth, role-transition theory. Singaporean scholar Paul Temporal proposed a new proposition that the role of brand management has changed significantly with the development of the times [1]. Accordingly, firms should be encouraged to innovate and

employees should be motivated in order to improve competitiveness [2]. Overall, this represents a relatively long-term cyclical management approach covering the entire brand process and is instructive.

#### **2.1.4 Brand Equity School — Emphasizing the Influence of Brand Equity Management on Consumer Perception**

Brand Equity is the added value endowed to a product or service. The core theory of the brand equity school recognizes the decisive role of brand equity in consumer perception, thereby pioneering a broad stream of subsequent research.

First, the pioneer — Aaker's brand equity theory and the Aaker Five-Star Model.

In 1988, the Marketing Science Institute (MSI) in the United States first proposed the concept of “Brand Equity,” pointing out a major direction for academic brand development and becoming the foundation of Aaker's theory. Subsequently, in 1991, David A. Aaker published *Managing Brand Equity* and made several major contributions: he addressed a number of fundamental questions about brand equity; argued that, compared with traditional brand image theory, brand equity is the key to competitive success; and, most importantly, proposed the “Aaker Five-Star Model,” namely, the basic elements of brand equity: brand loyalty, brand awareness, perceived quality, brand associations, and “other proprietary assets.”

This theory was revolutionary. First, brand equity mainly originates from consumers. Second, from a large number of potentially relevant elements, it identified and for the first time emphasized the contributions of “perceived quality,” “brand associations,” and “brand loyalty” to brand equity. In doing so, it pushed long-standing brand thought to a new peak. Even though Aaker's Five-Star Model gradually became less prominent after Keller's brand value chain model was proposed, it remains a classic.

Second, Keller's Customer-Based Brand Equity theory. In 1998, Keller made the following important innovations in *Strategic Brand Management* [13]: (1) an integrative and innovative scientific style, establishing a new “customer perspective” [19] on the basis of the traditional “financial perspective” and “market perspective”; (2) conceptual innovations such as brand associations, brand knowledge, and brand marketing; and (3) using the “brand

value chain” and “brand resonance model” as core foundations to address the difficult question since the 1980s of “how brands create value,” providing a rational and logical answer.

Objectively, this theory has both gains and limitations. On the one hand, it advanced the disciplinary methods of scientific research and established the logical system of modern brand theory. On the other hand, brands are not entirely rational in reality; Keller placed excessive emphasis on pure logic and rationality, making the theory appear relatively complicated and pale.

### **2.1.5 Brand Information School — Proposing the Influence of Information and Processing on Consumer Perception**

Adapting to the development of data and electronic information technologies in the new era, brand management also developed a new information school, mainly explaining how consumers use information, absorb information, and evaluate products and brands. Schmitt’s brand experience scale is a major representative example:

In 2000, Bernd H. Schmitt proposed in *Experiential Marketing* that traditional marketing focuses on “product attributes and benefits,” whereas “experiential marketing” focuses on the “customer experience.” In 2009, he designed a brand experience measurement scale with four dimensions: sensory, affective, behavioral, and intellectual, making abstract and flexible brand experience measurable.

“Brand experience theory” substantially transformed earlier research on “brand satisfaction.” The central actor in brand satisfaction was the firm, whereas the central actor in brand experience became the customer; the traditional perspective was supplier-led, whereas the new theory was customer-led. This represented a fundamental shift in the perspective on customer–brand relationships.

## **2.2 Review of Domestic Brand Management Research**

Since 1992, Chinese scholars have gradually studied the relationship between brand management and consumer perception, producing the following three major models and multiple theories:

### **2.2.1 Multi-Factor Model — Multiple Factors Jointly Affect Consumer Perception**

First, the Yinan 7F Model. In 2001, Liang Zhongguo proposed the Yinan 7F brand management model. It identifies seven drivers of brand growth: comprehensive research, market positioning, brand planning, brand review, brand promotion, brand monitoring, and brand enhancement. It places particular emphasis on responsiveness, that is, proposing targeted solutions according to different situations.

The Yinan 7F Model has milestone significance. It was the first relatively mature and comprehensive brand management operating model in China and provides strong practical guidance.

Second, the Seven Disciplines of Excellent Brands and the Eight Dimensions of Brand Competitiveness theory. In 2003, Li Guangdou proposed seven areas for building a brand in Seven Disciplines of Excellent Brands [5], namely: brand management, advertising management, publicity channel management, production management, human resource management, sales management, and knowledge management. In 2004, Brand Competitiveness introduced eight levels for improving brand competitiveness: brand core strength, brand market strength, brand loyalty strength, brand diffusion strength, brand innovation strength, brand vitality, brand cultural strength, and brand leadership strength.

This theory has both strengths and weaknesses. Although it systematically studied the factors influencing brands and proposed several new elements, its degree of innovation was relatively limited. It largely inherited the earlier views of the “Yinan 7F Model” without making a further breakthrough.

Third, the theory of the five supporting forces of a strong brand. In 2002, Zhang Bing proposed that a brand requires five supporting forces: corporate development strategy, internal corporate management, strong advertising and promotion, strong marketing capabilities, and outstanding product packaging. Similarly, the research did not develop deeply or open up new fields.

### **2.2.2 MBC Brand Management Model — Different Models Jointly**

## **Affect Consumer Perception**

In 2002, Chen Fang proposed a marketing systems engineering brand management model in *Brand Studies* [11]. Its main proposition is to use multiple models jointly to establish a favorable brand image. Its pioneering significance lies in elevating brand management to an independent discipline for the first time.

### **2.2.3 720-Degree Brand Management Model — Two Internal and External Corporate Behavior Circles Affect Consumer Perception**

In 2002, Su Xiaodong and others proposed the 720-degree brand management concept in *720-Degree Brand Management — Concepts and Applications* [10]. Its core idea is that two interconnected corporate behavior circles exist: an internal 360-degree corporate behavior circle including corporate strategy, employees, teams, and efficiency, and an external corporate behavior circle including products, customers, channels, and effectiveness. It also emphasizes integrating and controlling all elements at every point, line, and surface of contact between brands and consumers [17] in order to influence consumers' perceptions of brands.

This theory differs from previous research: earlier studies started from influencing elements, whereas the 720-degree brand management model innovatively approached the issue from an interactive business ecosystem.

In summary, the effectiveness of brand management on consumer perception remains worthy of further study:

Regarding the current state of domestic and international research, brand management theory among overseas firms is relatively well developed, and research continuously introduces new ideas in response to changing competitive conditions. By comparison, although Chinese research on brands has advanced in recent years, substantial research gaps remain [16] and require future scholars to address them.

Regarding exploration and resolution of the research topic, previous research has undeniably developed rich theories and substantial findings, yet many shortcomings remain to be addressed within this specific topic. First, academia has not reached a unified view on the brand management variables that influence consumer perception. As a focal point of debate,

different academic schools hold different positions and propose different categories and scopes of influencing factors. Second, research has mainly relied on qualitative analysis and has involved relatively little quantitative analysis. Although the major models each have their strengths, most are based mainly on scholars' subjective understanding and verbal summarization, while relatively few theories apply data processing and analysis or computer-based modeling methods, leaving substantial room for improvement in data utilization. Finally, previous research has not addressed the identification of effect magnitude. Earlier studies have carefully and broadly summarized many variables but have not evaluated the magnitude of each variable's effect on consumer perception, such as whether it greatly improves consumer perception, produces an effect around the middle of a normal distribution, or produces only a small improvement.

Therefore, building on the accumulated research of previous scholars, the author will make innovations in the following specific aspects: (1) screen the brand management factor variables that influence consumer perception and narrow their categories; (2) apply quantitative analysis to provide data support; and (3) analyze the specific effects of brand management on consumer perception.

### **3 Development Trends in Brand Management Research**

As contemporary markets become increasingly complex, firms face many new problems [15]: competitive pressure continues to increase; the development of information technology has brought major changes in emerging media; consumer psychology is becoming increasingly mature, and traditional brand management theories can no longer maintain sufficiently high brand loyalty; successful brands are widely imitated; retailers have become larger, more powerful, and better informed, leading them to demand more trade promotions in exchange for scarce shelf space and compressing brand profit margins; and some firms blindly apply brand marketing strategies and extend brands, causing core brand benefits to become blurred. All of these problems call for new solutions in brand management research. Therefore, future brand management research will generally develop in the following directions:

- (1) Emphasize corporate brands rather than individual product brands
- (2) Emphasize category management rather than traditional brand management
- (3) Emphasize customer-centered management rather than focusing only on brands
- (4) Emphasize brand leadership rather than ordinary brand management

## **II. List of Chinese and Foreign-Language References**

### **Consulted**

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# **The Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception**

## **— Evidence from the International Apparel Industry**

Major: International Business 182

Student Name: Keman Xiang

Supervisor: Fengjun Zhao

**Abstract:** The foreign-language references cited in this section cover major schools of thought in this research area, summaries of the historical development of research, and key branches of the field. They include articles examining the historical development of brand management research; studies of brand manager theory within the brand strategy school; studies of brand personality theory within the brand marketing school; articles examining consumer–brand relationships and consumer cognition; and studies of the impact of brand management on consumers and related methods. The writing purposes, research methods, and final findings of the foreign-language literature are summarized.

**Keywords:** brand management; historical development of research; brand manager theory; brand personality theory; consumer–brand relationship; consumer brand cognition; specific research methods

## Reference I

### **The Evolution of Brand Management Thinking over the Last 25 Years as Recorded in the Journal of Product & Brand Management**

Original Author: Cleopatra Veloutsou

Affiliation: Adam Smith Business School, University of Glasgow

Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. Journal of Product & Brand Management, 2017.

Keywords: Brand engagement, Brand experience, Brand communities, Brand management, Brand love, Brand relationships, Consumer brand equity, Financial brand equity, Brand hate, Brand as a person

Purpose – By outlining the evolution of brand management research over the past 25 years, as reported in the Journal of Product and Brand Management (JPBM), this paper aims to analyze the changes in the way branding has been approached in research, highlight the current challenges the discipline faces and suggest future research avenues that will hopefully further enrich brand management knowledge.

Design/methodology/approach – This paper includes internal historical literature review and commentary.

Findings – After a thorough analysis of the journal's content, the contribution that the JPBM has made in the development of brand management knowledge over the past 25 years is highlighted. Eight major shifts in brand management research and thought, and three overarching difficulties and challenges, are identified.

Research limitations/implications – By solely focusing on the contributions published in the journal, by no means this review is exhaustive and includes all the contributions to the discipline. Its contribution is limited to the analysis of the work, and the evolution of brand management thinking, recorded in the JPBM.

Originality/value – The paper highlights the evolution of brand management thought and presents imperatives and challenges to guide future research in brand management.

## Reference II

### **Brands, Brand Management, and the Brand Manager System: A Critical-Historical Evaluation**

Original Authors: GEORGE S. LOW, RONALD A. FULLERTON

Affiliation: None specified

Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. Journal of Marketing Research, 1994, 31(2): 173–190.

Keywords: Brand engagement, History, Development, Brand Manager System, Adoption,

The authors examine the history of brand management by tracing its development in the context of the marketing environment from 1870 to the present. They develop six theses regarding the evolution of brand management and its implications and substantiate them utilizing a historical approach. They demonstrate that the brand manager system originated well after the leadership of branded products was established, it was adopted following a conventional adoption curve pattern, and it has proven quite adaptable to differing firm and marketing environments over the past several decades. They then evaluate its likely fate in today's rapidly changing environment.

## Reference III

### **Brand Management Perspectives in the Twenty-First Century**

Original Authors: Ram Herstein and Moti Zvilling

Affiliation: Ruppin Academic Center, Emek Hefer, Israel

Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. Qualitative Market Research: An International Journal, 2011.

Keywords: Brand management, Long-term planning, Short-term planning, Brands, Manufacturer-Consumer Relationship

**Purpose** – The purpose of this study is to define the tasks of product managers from the perspective of professional brand managers and to point out the gaps between their short- and long-term tasks.

**Design/methodology/approach** – The paper conducted two studies: the first utilized a focus group in order to define the tasks of brand managers. In the second study, 58 brand managers were interviewed using in-depth interviews in order to define the various factors of each of the nine branding aspects. In the second phase of the second study, the participants were asked to point out gaps between the brand managers' long- and short-term perspectives.

**Findings** – The findings indicate that the daily pressure on brand managers comes from the distributors, who are the decisive factor in the threefold connection (manufacturer-distributor-consumer) due to their strong position in the market and the ongoing requirement to learn from and to satisfy them significantly more than the competition.

**Practical implications** – The implications of the study to the brand managers' approach is that they should nurture relationships with consumers, perform more frequent market segmentations in order to identify new needs, and consequently reduce the distributors' power.

**Originality/value** – The importance of this research is that it provides a new definition for brand managers' tasks and copes with the real gaps between the short-term and the long-term perspectives of brand management, and as such supplies substantial qualitative data for better decision making in accordance with the twenty-first century challenges of the brand managers.

## Reference IV

### **Brand Management Through Narrowing the Gap Between Brand Identity and Brand Reputation**

Original Author: Leslie de Chernatony

Affiliation: Open University Business School

Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. Journal of Marketing Management, 1999, 15(1–3): 157–179.

Keywords: Brand management, Brand Identity, Brand Reputation, Inside Corporation, Impact and Performance, Consumer perception, Gap Reduction,

**Purpose** – This paper therefore predominantly explores issues internal to the organisation, and clarifies the significance to brand building of culture, staff alignment, and brand identity. It then looks externally at the importance of reputation and concludes by considering how brand management can be conceived as minimizing the gap between the brand's identity and its reputation.

**Findings** – Classical models of brand management pay insufficient attention to staff as brand builders, placing more emphasis on external issues such as image. This paper explores the significant contribution from employees and considers the need to align their values and behaviours with the brand's desired values. It clarifies the importance of culture in brand building and discusses how an adaptive, strategically appropriate culture, consistently apparent throughout an organisation is likely to be associated with healthy brand performance. A model is proposed, suggesting that stronger brands result from a homogeneous brand identity, with congruent identity components. It argues that reputation is a more appropriate external assessment of a brand's own image. By auditing the gaps between brand identity and brand reputation, managers can identify strategies to minimize incongruency and develop more powerful brands. It is concluded that brand reality is an important aspect of branding.

## Reference V

### **Building Brand Commitment: A Behavioural Approach to Internal Brand Management**

Original Authors: CHRISTOPH BURMANN, SABRINA ZEPLIN

Affiliation: University of Bremen, Germany

Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. Journal of Brand Management, 2005, 12(4): 279–300.

Keywords: Brand management, Consumer Behavioural, Identity, Brand Commitment, Brand Citizenship Behaviour,

Findings – In this paper a holistic model for internal brand management is presented. It is based on the identity-based brand management approach according to which a brand — just like a person — needs to have a consistent and continuous identity in order to be trusted. Focusing on the role of employees in ensuring consistency of the brand identity, two new behavioural constructs are developed. The first construct — brand citizenship behaviour — outlines what it means for employees to ‘live the brand’. The second construct — brand commitment — explains the psychological processes that lead employees to show brand citizenship behaviour. Three key levers for generating brand commitment (brand-centred human resources management, brand communication and brand leadership) and four context factors (culture fit, structure fit, employee know-how and disposable resources) are illustrated as building blocks of internal brand management. The theoretical insights are complemented by many real-life examples extracted from in-depth interviews with brand managers and experts.

## Reference VI

### **Brand Management in Small to Medium-Sized Enterprises**

Original Authors: Pierre Berthon, Michael T. Ewing, Julie Napoli

Affiliation: None specified

Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. *Journal of Small Business Management*, 2008, 46(1): 27–45.

Keywords: Brand management, Small to Medium-Sized Enterprises, Gaps, SME, LOs,

**Purpose** –To address gaps, the present study seeks to identify the nature and scope of brand management within an SME context by comparing such practices to those of LOs. We commence by outlining the characteristics of SMEs and (some of the) marketing challenges they face. We then describe the present study, discuss the results, note the limitations, and highlight possible directions for future research in this area.

**Design/methodology/approach** –This study examined the nature and scope of brand management in SMEs. Specifically, we sought to first identify whether BMPs employed by SMEs varies to that of LOs and second, whether such differences extend to high- and low-performing SMEs.

**Findings** – The results indicate that there are certainly differences between SMEs and LOs in the extent to which they implement key BMPs. It is evident from the results that SMEs and LOs alike are both cognizant of the need to deliver relevant and desirable brands to customers. However, the BMPs of LOs are certainly geared more toward understanding and monitoring consumer needs and measuring the effectiveness of past actions.

It is also evident from the results that the 10 BMP dimensions are effective in discriminating between high- and lowperforming small and large organizations. More importantly, it seems that high-performing SMEs implement key BMPs to a greater extent than lowperforming SMEs. Brand-focused SMEs are able to achieve a distinct performance advantage over rivals by essentially getting back to the “branding basics”: that is, understanding customers’ needs and brand perceptions, creating relevant and valued brands, supporting the brand consistently over time, effectively communicating the brand’s identity to internal and external stakeholders and creating a coherent brand architecture. Such activities are well noted in the literature as necessary for building and managing brand equity in the long term (Keller 1999, 1998; Shocker, Srivastava, and Ruekert 1994; Park, Jaworski, and MacInnis 1986). In particular, this suggests that there is the potential for SMEs to optimize their performance by mirroring and adapting the brand management activities of their larger counterparts to their specific needs and circumstances. Ultimately, this should go some way toward contributing to the ongoing performance of organizations.

## Reference VII

### **A Process Model of Brand Cocreation: Brand Management and Research Implications**

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Source of Foreign-Language Literature: [J]. Journal of Product & Brand Management, 2007.

Keywords: Brands, Brand management, Consumer behaviour, Marketing communications, Product development,

**Purpose** – In light of the increasing acceptance of the concept of brand cocreation this paper aims to develop a model of the process in order to elucidate the roles of the various stakeholders, particularly the company and the brand consumers, in it and the implications of the concept for brand managers.

**Design/methodology/approach** – The process model of brand cocreation was derived from extant literature covering a wide range of topics related to brands, including: various types of marketing, consumer behaviour, psychology, new product development, and marketing communications.

**Findings** – A five-stage process of brand cocreation is developed identifying the various stages in which the firm is in control and those which are controlled by the consumers.

**Practical implications** – The paper highlights the need to reconsider the role of brand managers in the brand cocreation process and identifies various gaps in the knowledge of brands and their management that have become apparent as a result of the development of the model.

**Originality/value** – The value of this paper lies in its holistic overview of the complete brand cocreation process and the issues relating to the nature of brand management that it highlights.

杭 州 師 範 大 學  
HANGZHOU NORMAL UNIVERSITY

UNDERGRADUATE THESIS

(Class of 2022)

|              |                                                       |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Thesis Title | The Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception |
|              | — Evidence from the International Apparel Industry    |

|              |                        |                |                            |
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April 3, 2022

## ABSTRACT

How to effectively manage brand and how to use brand management to improve consumer cognition is a hot topic of enterprises. Therefore, this paper focuses on the role of brand management on consumer cognition in the international apparel industry, and discusses which methods of brand management are more effective in improving consumer awareness.

This paper adopts literature research method, quantitative analysis method, and empirical analysis method. It uses the data of "Global Consumer Survey 2021" of Statista Company and the annual reports of companies. Also, it utilizes Statista's statistical tools to carry out regression analysis.

The research results show that, first, brand management is positively correlated with consumer cognition; second, the brand management factors that affect consumers' brand cognition are brand positioning and brand marketing, and the factors that affect consumers' brand attitude are brand image, the factors of purchase intention are brand positioning, brand image and brand marketing; thirdly, among the brand management methods, brand marketing has the greatest effect on enhancing consumers' cognition.

This research has theoretical and practical significance. It not only provides quantitative support for previous research, but also provides guidance on brand management methods for Chinese garment enterprises, promoting Chinese enterprises to learn from international experience and build their own brands.

**Keywords:** brand management; consumer cognition; role research; international apparel industry

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# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 Research Background, Objectives, and Significance

### 1.1.1 Research Background

Brand building and brand management have long been policy priorities of the CPC Central Committee and the State Council. Since the State Council released Made in China 2025 and Several Opinions of the State Council on Accelerating the Development of an Intellectual Property Power under the New Situation in 2015, attention to brand operations has gradually increased. In 2016, Premier Li Keqiang stated in the government work report delivered at the Fourth Session of the Twelfth National People's Congress that China should "cultivate an outstanding spirit of craftsmanship, increase product variety, improve quality, and build brands," and further emphasized the need to "build golden brands of Chinese manufacturing." In 2017, the State Council designated May 10 of each year as "China Brand Day" and, in its opinions on brand building, incorporated the "China Brand Strategy" into the development program for strengthening brand and cultural capabilities in the new era. Therefore, studying the impact of brand management on consumer perception, and thereby providing theoretical guidance for the development of brand practice, has strong national strategic significance, practical demand, and relevance to future development trends.

### 1.1.2 Research Objectives

This study has two main research objectives:

First, to identify the brand management factors that affect consumer perception. The core task is to screen effective influencing factors on the basis of the various theories in the academic literature.

Second, to examine the effectiveness of the above brand management factors in influencing consumer perception. Based on quantitative data, the study analyzes the effects of different factors.

### 1.1.3 Research Significance

Research on the effectiveness of brand management in influencing consumer perception has major theoretical and practical significance:

### 1.1.3.1 Theoretical Significance

(1) Focusing on a long-standing academic debate and providing empirical evidence and analytical conclusions.

Which factors of brand management affect consumer perception has long been a central topic of academic discussion. Different schools and viewpoints have put forward their own arguments, and no unified answer that is convincing to all sides has yet been reached. On the basis of absorbing the experience and conclusions of prior studies, this thesis conducts further analysis. Its core approach is to treat the influencing factors supported by major theories as original variables, objectively test their effects on consumer perception, and thereby derive an effectiveness analysis that can provide a basis for distinguishing among and referring to different theoretical perspectives.

(2) Focusing on quantitative analysis.

Previous studies mainly used qualitative methods and reached relatively broad and subjective conclusions, without experimentally measuring and comparing the effectiveness of individual factors. By contrast, this study emphasizes quantitative analysis and specifically applies multiple data-analysis approaches, including Stata statistical analysis, text mining, website searches, and keyword-ranking analysis, to provide a scientific basis for the research conclusions.

(3) Focusing on the innovation of effectiveness analysis.

Previous research has mainly focused on which factors of brand management influence consumer perception. Although such research is undoubtedly valuable, it has not involved comparing the “different degrees of effectiveness of the various brand management factors on consumer perception,” leaving a gap in this specific area. By contrast, this study focuses on analyzing the different effects produced by different factors and presents them quantitatively, providing a new perspective for academic research.

### 1.1.3.2 Practical Significance

At the national level, developing Chinese brands.

With the development of globalization, competition in international markets is becoming increasingly intense, and China urgently needs to secure an important position in the global market. On the one hand, research on this topic responds to the advocacy of the “China Brand

Strategy,” provides theoretical support and reference for practice, promotes the development of independent national brands, strengthens cultural confidence, and helps Chinese brands gain wider international recognition. On the other hand, it can respond to the requirements of structural reform in the new era, promote high-quality brand building and brand upgrading, and support entry into a new stage of development.

At the enterprise level, providing theoretical guidance for corporate business strategy.

Contemporary small and medium-sized enterprises generally face constraints in capital, talent, technological investment, and other resources. Analyzing the effectiveness of different brand management factors on consumer perception can provide a basis for resource-allocation decisions, helping firms direct limited resources to the most efficient areas and maximize the output-input ratio.

## **1.2 Current State of Research**

### **1.2.1 Current State of Brand Theory Research**

Overall, the major focus areas of brand theory research have roughly passed through five key stages.

#### **1.2.1.1 Brand Stage**

The brand stage was the period in which the concept of the brand was first introduced. The basic scientific questions at this stage included two issues: (1) what is a brand; and (2) why are brands needed?

##### **1) Definition of the brand.**

First, Gardner and Levy (1955) introduced the idea of the brand. Next, Light and King (1960), through their research on brand extension, developed a standardized definition of a brand. Ultimately, these perspectives converged on the definition of a brand adopted by the American Marketing Association (AMA).

##### **2) Brand naming.**

First, early scholars attached considerable importance to brand names. Kotler and Armstrong (1997) argued that a good brand name can bring consumers a high level of awareness and a strong sense of taste. Accordingly, many scholars proposed principles for brand naming, including McNeal and Zeren (1981), McCarthy and Perreault (1987),

Robertson (1989), Keller (1993), and Kotler and Armstrong (1997).

Second, many new studies emerged involving cross-cultural and multilingual contexts. For example, Zhang and Schmitt (2001) examined consumers' evaluations of brand-name translation in bilingual Chinese-English environments.

### **1.2.1.2 Brand Strategy Stage**

At this stage, the focus shifted from brands to branding, and how to build a brand became a new proposition. This stage can be divided into brand identification and brand planning.

Its basic questions include (1) brand-related decisions, (2) how to shape brand image through branding, and (3) how to plan brand strategy.

#### **3) Brand image.**

Brand image theory was first proposed by Ogilvy (1963) and Herzog (1963).

In general, researchers have conducted related studies from two different perspectives: brand image from the customer perspective and brand image management from the company perspective. The former mainly emphasizes consumers' awareness, reputation, and associations regarding the company, whereas the latter treats brand image as an intangible corporate asset that creates differentiated competitive advantages and asset returns. It emphasizes that brand image can be used in the market to build effective barriers to entry.

#### **4) Brand positioning.**

Ries and Trout (1979) were pioneers of positioning theory. Kotler and Keller (2006) argued that brand positioning lies at the core of marketing strategy. Keller (2008) proposed the positioning framework based on points of parity and points of difference (POP/POD).

#### **5) Brand hierarchy.**

Keller (2008) proposed the brand hierarchy, an effective tool for planning a company's brand strategy using a hierarchical graphical approach. It can clearly define the hierarchical order among brands and the relationships between brands and products. Keller (1998) also used the term "architecture" to describe a company's brand architecture.

#### **6) Brand portfolio.**

D. Aaker (1991) introduced the concept of the brand portfolio and discussed the roles and functions of different brands within a company's brand portfolio.

Many scholars have studied the role of brand portfolio management. D. Aaker (2004)

argued that brand portfolios should be managed by promoting synergies among brands, maximizing brand equity, creating and maintaining market relevance, and creating and sustaining strong brands. Bergen et al. (1996) examined the role of brand portfolios. Anand and Shachar (2004) argued that they can improve loyalty. Broniarczyk et al. (1998) suggested that they can provide better customer service and maximize profits. Keller (2008) summarized eight action points.

In addition, Hill et al. (2005) proposed five steps for designing an ideal brand portfolio.

### **1.2.1.3 Brand Equity Stage**

The basic scientific questions in brand equity research include (1) the sources of brand equity, (2) component models of brand equity, and (3) the evaluation and measurement of brand equity.

#### **1) Brand value chain.**

To answer the question of where brand equity comes from, Keller and Lehmann (2003) proposed the brand value chain model. An extended version of the brand value chain was subsequently proposed in 2006. From the perspective of conceptual models, Lu Taihong et al. (2000) divided the sources of brand equity into three categories: financial-accounting models, market-based brand power models, and consumer-based models.

#### **2) Brand equity.**

Scholars differ in their definitions of brand equity, but their understanding can mainly be grouped into three perspectives: customer-based brand equity (Farquhar, 1990), market-effect-based brand equity (D. Aaker, 1991), and financial-market-output-based brand equity (Keller, 1993 and 1998).

#### **3) Brand equity component models.**

Keller proposed the CBBE model in 1993, helping customer-based brand equity research become a mainstream research area. The CBBE model contains four key elements: brand identity, brand meaning, brand response, and brand relationships.

Other scholars have advanced perspectives from different angles. Jiang Lianxiong (2008) critically examined brand knowledge from the perspectives of cognitive psychology, consumer behavior, brand characteristics, and integrity. D. Aaker (1991 and 1998) proposed the five-star model of brand equity and a ten-element model of brand equity. Brand consulting

firms have also proposed models for measuring brand equity.

#### **1.2.1.4 Brand Management Stage**

The basic questions studied during the brand management stage are (1) the long-term requirements of brand management and (2) the performance of brand management.

The approximately 120-year history of brand operations can be divided into four major stages: (1) the development stage of domestic manufacturer brands (1870-1914); (2) the stage of brand operations facing new challenges (1915-1929); (3) the birth of the brand manager system (1930-1945); and (4) the era of brand managers (1950-1990).

This will be described in detail in Section 1.2.2.

#### **1.2.1.5 Brand Relationship Stage**

The basic scientific questions in brand relationship research are (1) the categories of brand relationships, (2) how to measure them, and (3) how to develop them.

Since the 1990s, research on brand relationships has emerged. Major literature in this stage includes Blackston's (1992 and 1995) brand relationship model, Fournier's (1994 and 1998) framework for brand relationship analysis, and Aggarwal's (2004) study of brand relationship communication norms.

### **1.2.2 Current State of Brand Management Theory Research**

Since the development of brand theory, many works on branding have used "brand management" as a key term, listed numerous real-world branding cases, and comprehensively analyzed problems in brand management.

#### **1.2.2.1 Brand Extension and Brand Enhancement**

Tauber (1979) first proposed the idea of brand extension. Theoretical research on brand extension mainly follows two directions: one examines the conditions that facilitate successful extension from the parent brand to an extended brand, and the other examines the feedback effects of the extended brand on the parent brand.

First, research has identified effective conditions for successful extension from a parent brand to an extended brand. D. Aaker and Keller (1990), Klink and Smith (2001), and van Osselaer and Alba (2003) argued that identifying the compatibility between the extension and the parent brand is very important. Bottomley and Holden (2001) also found that the strength

of the parent brand itself and the interaction between the parent brand and the extension have significant effects. In addition, consumers' brand knowledge (Moreau et al., 2001), consumer characteristics, and extension characteristics (Barone and Miniard, 2002; Maoz and Tybout, 2002; Zhang and Sood, 2002) also have an influence.

Second, scholars have also noted that an extended brand can affect the parent brand, that is, the feedback effect of brand extension. This effect mainly occurs in two ways. One is to strengthen (or weaken) consumers' memory and recall of the parent brand; the other is to change consumers' beliefs about and evaluations of the parent brand. Keller and D. Aaker (1991), Romeo (1991), Loken and Roedder John (1993), and Ahluwalia and Gurhan-Canli (2000) argued that failure of a brand extension occurs only when the extension is highly similar to or compatible with the parent brand. Balachander and Ghose (2003) examined the positive feedback effect of brand extensions on the parent brand.

#### **1.2.2.2 Brand Revitalization**

Berry (1988) first introduced the concept, and Lehu (2004) was the first scholar to conduct empirical research on it.

There are two main research paths. One investigates the causes of brand aging, while the other investigates the mechanisms and paths of brand revitalization. The main research methods include qualitative research, empirical analysis (Clancy, 2001; Muzelec, 2003), and case studies (Ewing, 1995). Lu Taihong and Gao Hui (2007) conducted a comprehensive investigation of brand aging and brand revitalization and explained in detail the conditions and strategies for brand revitalization from the perspectives of enterprises and consumers.

#### **1.2.2.3 Brand Alliances**

Rao and Ruekert (1994) first proposed the concept of brand alliances.

Academic research on brand alliances mainly focuses on the conditions for successful brand alliances, the contexts in which brand alliances are applicable, consumer attitudes after brand alliances, and spillover effects on participating brands. First, regarding conditions, Simonin and Ruth (1998) argued that customers' attitudes toward brand cooperation affect the reputation of the partner brands. Second, applications in different contexts mainly include the use of brand alliances in advertising (Grossman, 1997), the role of brand alliances in brand extension (Park, 1996), applications in service industries (Levin, 2000), the use of national

and local brand alliances (Vaidyanathan and Aggarwal, 2000), and the effects of different combinations on brand alliances (Judith, 1999). Finally, regarding the effects of brand alliances on participating brands, studies have examined brand attitude (Park and Srinivasan, 1994), brand image (Grossman, 1997), brand identification (Sridhar et al., 1999), brand trust (Sridhar et al., 1999), brand loyalty (Judith, 1999), and brand equity (Levin, 2000).

#### **1.2.2.4 Brand Management Performance and Balance**

Research on brand management performance emphasizes the output effects of brands. This differs considerably from earlier research that focused on brand management inputs.

Brand management performance is mainly reflected in brand value. Scholars who have studied brand value include Nilson (1998), Ellwood (2002), Mozota (2004), Arvidsson (2005), Turkel (2006), and Lehu (2006).

### **1.2.3 Current State of Research on the Impact of Brand Management on Consumer Perception**

#### **1.2.3.1 Review of Foreign Research**

##### **1) Brand Semiotics School - Focusing on the Impact of Visual Symbols on Consumer Perception**

The brand semiotics school is a traditional school from the early development of brand management. Its main focus is to answer the question, “How do consumers identify brands?” The following theories are among the most influential:

First, Brand Identity theory. Brand identity was a key focus of early brand research, represented primarily by J. N. Kapferer in Europe and David A. Aaker in the United States. Kapferer examined how different means, such as names and logos, can express the question of “who am I?” for a brand [1]; on the other hand, in *Building Strong Brands* (1996) [2], Aaker both agreed with and qualified Kapferer’s view. He argued that (1) firms should give brands unique and explicit meanings, and (2) a comprehensive identification system should be established for a brand rather than relying only on a name or logo. The latter view further developed Kapferer’s perspective.

The brand semiotics school had a significant theoretical influence and stimulated a historical wave of commercial and advertising creative design. CIS (Corporate Identity

System) was also highly popular for a period. However, after the 1990s, this line of research moved from the center toward the periphery.

Second, Levy's brand image theory. Product and Brand [3], published by S. J. Levy and B. B. Gardner in 1955, pioneered a rational understanding of brands and, in particular, creatively introduced the concept of "brand image" (BI), regarding it as the key distinction between a brand and a product. "Brand image" has profound significance: it created market imagination and commercial opportunities and promoted the development of advertising, design, and communication industries. It remained active until later research on "brand associations" gradually replaced its importance.

Third, Park's three-dimensional brand concept (BCM). Because the preceding research remained relatively limited and had not fully explored the independent value of brands, C. W. Park in the United States was not satisfied with "brand image" and argued that deeper differences between brands and products existed beneath their outward appearance. He proposed a deeper structure of the brand concept [4]: brands have three dimensions - functional, experiential, and symbolic. The significance of this theory lies in opening broad space for the development of modern brand management theory, including areas such as brand experience and the meaning of brand symbolism.

Fourth, USP theory, represented by Rosser Reeves and the Bates Advertising Company. First, in the early 1950s, Reeves proposed the traditional USP theory [5], emphasizing that (1) advertising should communicate a clear consumer benefit proposition and (2) differentiation of each proposition is fundamental. Second, in the 1990s, Bates inherited and developed Reeves's theory. The new view held that the creativity of a unique selling proposition lies in revealing the essence of a brand and powerfully demonstrating its uniqueness [6]. In summary, both perspectives emphasize the importance of brand uniqueness and promoted the diversification of visual expression.

## **2) Brand Marketing School - Emphasizing the Impact of Marketing Strategy on Consumer Perception**

The brand marketing school inherited and developed earlier research. It not only recognized the role of visual effects but placed greater emphasis on the importance of marketing:

First, David Ogilvy's brand image theory. Earlier studies emphasized the expression of product differentiation through visual effects, but as markets developed and product differences narrowed, distinguishing products through product characteristics became increasingly difficult. In the 1950s, David Ogilvy proposed brand image theory [7], whose central argument was that creating an attractive brand image is critical and that advertising, as a long-term investment, plays an important role in shaping brand image.

Compared with traditional symbolic perspectives, brand image theory represented a different development. It viewed brand management not as a single factor but as a systematic project involving products, marketing, services, and other aspects, and held that shaping a brand image requires long-term commitment from all employees of an enterprise.

Second, positioning theory, represented by Jack Trout and Al Ries. As products became increasingly homogeneous, it became more difficult for the brand image theory discussed above to support firms in creating product differentiation, and positioning theory emerged in response. In 1979, Jack Trout and Al Ries first proposed positioning theory in *Positioning* [8], arguing that firms should start from the consumer perspective and occupy a favorable position in consumers' minds from the outside in; therefore, consumer research should be used to identify a product's unique market position. Positioning theory has had a profound influence and provides strong practical guidance for contemporary brand positioning strategies.

Third, brand personality theory, led by Grey, Kobayashi, and Jennifer Aaker. In the 1960s, Grey Advertising in the United States proposed a "brand personality philosophy," while Japan's Kobayashi proposed a "corporate personality theory." Their main views were: (1) among logo, image, and personality, personality is the highest level; (2) brands should be personified; (3) core graphics or thematic copy should be emphasized; and (4) symbolic objects should be emphasized. On this basis, in 1997 Jennifer Aaker established another milestone by using empirical methods to derive the "Big Five" model of brand personality [9]. This not only made brand personality an important new concept but also provided a basic reference framework for brand personality.

In terms of significance, on the one hand, brand personality further developed the earlier research on "brand image." Brand image is external, whereas brand personality is internal, opening a new direction for the personification of brands. On the other hand, brand

personality laid a foundation for subsequent research on brand relationships.

Fourth, Fournier's consumer-brand relationship theory. In the 1990s, American scholar S. Fournier pioneered the field of consumer-brand relationships, with "brand relationship quality" (BRQ) [10] as a core concept. Fournier was innovative in several respects: she combined affective and rational approaches, provided a method for measuring consumer-brand relationships, and shifted the traditional one-way perspective toward multilateral interactive relationships. Her consumer-brand relationship model therefore became a theoretical starting point for subsequent research.

Fifth, A. M. Muniz's brand community theory. In response to the digital trend of the new century, Muniz published *Brand Community* in 2001 [11], arguing for the leading role of social media and communities. This theory opened a new direction for consumer-brand relationships and became a major area of academic research, making experience, interaction, sharing, immersion, and the brand ecosystem increasingly active topics.

### **3) Brand Strategy School - Emphasizing the Impact of Systematic Management on Consumer Perception**

The strategy school elevated brand management to a new level by examining corporate management processes and consumer responses from an overall perspective:

First, two major theories of brand leadership.

The early corporate brand manager system. In 1931, Neil McElroy of Procter & Gamble pioneered the brand manager system, arguing that a brand manager should coordinate and manage the process as a whole and bear full responsibility. The system has both advantages and disadvantages: it is mature and competitive, but it is also time-consuming and has limited universal applicability.

As traditional brand management models revealed shortcomings in a changing environment, such as difficulty handling multiple brands, brand extensions, and sub-brands, Aaker proposed a new theory of brand leadership in *Brand Leadership* in 2000[12]. It differs from the earlier model on several important points: Aaker emphasizes the CEO as the brand manager, whereas the earlier model favored a brand manager; he emphasizes strategy rather than tactical orientation; and he emphasizes a broad management scope rather than a limited one. Overall, Aaker revised the traditional theory in multiple respects.

Second, the more recent theories of Brand Stewardship and 360-Degree Brand Management. In the early 1990s, Ogilvy introduced “Brand Stewardship” [13], which essentially uses comprehensive corporate planning to ensure that brand-related activities reflect the brand’s core spirit. In the mid-1990s, it further proposed “360-Degree Brand Management” [14], which emphasizes ensuring complete communication management at every point of contact with consumers. Both theories are proactive and actively reach and manage the relationship between brands and consumers.

Third, integrated marketing and communication interaction theory. Integrated marketing (IM) was proposed by Tom Duncan and Sandra Moriarty in *Driving Brand Value: Using Integrated Marketing to Manage Profitable Stakeholder Relationships* [15]. In essence, integrated marketing is a business model that explains the cross-functional integration process through which firms create, maintain, and strengthen brand relationships, while also emphasizing communication and interaction within brand relationship networks. Its distinctive significance lies in approaching the issue from the perspective of intangible asset management, distinguishing it from traditional research on tangible assets.

Fourth, role-transition theory. Singaporean scholar Paul Temporal proposed that the role of brand management has changed significantly with the development of the times [16]. Accordingly, firms should encourage innovation and motivate employees to improve competitiveness. In general, the theory treats brand management as a relatively long-term cyclical management process covering the entire brand process and is therefore instructive.

#### **4) Brand Equity School - Emphasizing the Impact of Brand Equity Management on Consumer Perception**

Brand equity is the added value endowed to a product or service. The core theory of the brand equity school recognizes the decisive role of brand equity in consumer perception and opened the way for extensive subsequent research.

First, the pioneer - Aaker’s brand equity theory and Aaker’s Five-Star Model.

In 1988, the Marketing Science Institute (MSI) in the United States first introduced the concept of “brand equity” [17], setting a major direction for academic brand research and forming the foundation of Aaker’s theory. Subsequently, in 1991 David A. Aaker published *Managing Brand Equity* [18], making several major contributions: answering basic questions

about brand equity; arguing that brand equity, rather than traditional brand image theory, is the key to competitive success; and, most importantly, proposing the “Aaker Five-Star Model.”

The basic elements of brand equity in this model are brand loyalty, brand awareness, perceived quality, brand associations, and “other proprietary assets.”

This theory was revolutionary. First, brand equity mainly comes from consumers. Second, from among many potentially relevant elements, it extracted and emphasized for the first time the contributions of “perceived quality,” “brand associations,” and “brand loyalty” to brand equity. In this way, it brought long-standing thinking about brands to a new level. Even though Aaker’s Five-Star Model gradually became less prominent after Keller proposed the brand value chain model, it remains a classic.

Second, Keller’s customer-based brand equity theory. In 1998, Keller introduced several major innovations in Strategic Brand Management [19]: (1) an integrative and innovative scientific approach that established a new “customer perspective” on the basis of the traditional “financial perspective” and “market perspective”; (2) conceptual innovations such as brand associations, brand knowledge, and brand marketing; and (3) the “brand value chain” and “brand resonance model” as core foundations, providing a rational and logical answer to the difficult question since the 1980s of “how brands create value.”

Objectively, this theory has both strengths and weaknesses. On the one hand, it advanced the disciplinary methods of scientific research and established a logical system for modern brand theory. On the other hand, brands are not entirely rational, and Keller placed excessive emphasis on pure logic and rationality, making the theory appear somewhat complicated and abstract.

### **5) Brand Information School - Proposing the Impact of Information and Processing on Consumer Perception**

Adapting to the development of data and electronic information technology in the new era, brand management also formed a new information school, mainly explaining how consumers use and absorb information and evaluate products and brands. Schmitt’s brand experience scale is a major representative example:

In 2000, Bernd H. Schmitt proposed in Experiential Marketing [20] that traditional

marketing focuses on “product attributes and benefits,” whereas “experiential marketing” focuses on the “customer experience.” In 2009, he designed a scale for measuring brand experience [21], with four dimensions: sensory, affective, behavioral, and intellectual, allowing abstract and subjective brand experience to be measured.

“Brand experience theory” substantially transformed earlier research on “brand satisfaction.” In brand satisfaction, the central actor is the enterprise, whereas in brand experience, the central actor shifts to the customer. Traditional thinking is supplier-led, while the new theory is customer-led, representing a fundamental shift in the perspective on customer-brand relationships.

### **1.2.3.2 Review of Domestic Brand Management Research**

Since 1992, Chinese academic research has gradually examined the relationship between brand management and consumer perception, producing the following three major models and multiple theories:

#### **1) Multi-Factor Model - Multiple Factors Jointly Affect Consumer Perception**

First, the Yinan 7F model. In 2001, Liang Zhongguo proposed the Yinan 7F brand management model [22], identifying seven driving forces of brand growth: comprehensive investigation, market positioning, brand planning, brand evaluation, brand promotion, brand monitoring, and brand enhancement. The model places particular emphasis on responsiveness, proposing targeted solutions according to different situations.

The Yinan 7F model has milestone significance. It was the first relatively mature and complete brand management operating model in China and provides strong practical guidance.

Second, the theory of Seven Practices for Excellent Brands and Eight Dimensions of Brand Competitiveness. In 2003, Li Guangdou proposed seven approaches to building a brand in Seven Practices for Excellent Brands [23], namely brand management, advertising management, promotional-channel management, production management, human-resource management, sales management, and knowledge management. In 2004, Brand Competitiveness introduced eight levels for enhancing brand competitiveness: core brand strength, market strength, loyalty strength, radiation strength, innovation strength, vitality, cultural strength, and leadership strength.

This theory has both strengths and weaknesses. Although it systematically studies brand-influencing factors and proposes several new elements, its innovation is relatively limited and largely follows the earlier Yinan 7F model without going much further.

Third, the theory of five supporting forces for a strong brand. In 2002, Zhang Bing proposed that a brand requires five supporting forces: corporate development strategy, internal corporate management, strong advertising, strong marketing capability, and outstanding product packaging. Similarly, this research did not explore the issue in greater depth or open a new research area.

## **2) MBC Brand Management Model - Different Models Jointly Affect Consumer Perception**

In 2002, Chen Fang proposed a brand management model based on marketing systems engineering in Brand Studies. Its main argument is that multiple models should be used together to establish a favorable brand image. Its pioneering significance lies in elevating brand management to an independent discipline for the first time.

## **3) 720-Degree Brand Management Model - Two Internal and External Corporate Behavior Circles Affect Consumer Perception**

In 2002, Su Xiaodong et al. proposed the idea of 720-degree brand management in 720-Degree Brand Management: Concepts and Operations. The core idea is that there are two interconnected circles of corporate behavior: an internal 360-degree behavior circle consisting of corporate strategy, employees, teams, and efficiency, and an external behavior circle consisting of products, customers, channels, and effectiveness. It also emphasizes integrating and controlling all elements at every point, line, and surface of contact between a brand and consumers in order to influence consumers' perceptions of the brand.

This theory differs from earlier research: previous studies started from individual influencing elements, whereas the 720-degree brand management model innovatively begins with the interacting business ecosystem.

In summary, the effectiveness of brand management in influencing consumer perception still deserves further study:

Regarding the current state of domestic and international research, theories of corporate

brand management abroad are relatively mature and continuously innovate in response to changes in the competitive environment. By comparison, although research on brands in China has advanced in recent years, substantial research gaps remain and require further improvement by future scholars.

Regarding the exploration and resolution of the research topic, although previous research is theoretically rich and has produced substantial results, many shortcomings remain within this specific topic. First, academia has not reached a unified view on which brand management variables affect consumer perception. As a central point of debate, different academic schools hold different views on the categories and scope of influencing factors. Second, prior research is dominated by qualitative analysis and involves relatively little quantitative analysis. Although the major models each have their own strengths, most rely primarily on scholars' subjective understanding and verbal generalization, while relatively few apply data processing and analysis or computer-based modeling methods, leaving considerable room for improvement in the use of data. Finally, prior research has not distinguished the magnitude of influence. It has identified many variables in a detailed and broad manner but has not evaluated the effect of each variable on consumer perception, such as whether the effect is very large, around the middle of a normal distribution, or relatively small.

### **1.3 Research Content and Research Methods**

#### **1.3.1 Research Content**

This study aims to explore the following questions:

- 1) Which brand management factors affect consumer perception? That is, which brand management factors influence consumer perception?
- 2) How strong is the impact of the above factors on consumer perception? That is, what is the effect of brand management factors on consumer perception?

#### **1.3.2 Research Methods**

##### **1) Literature Review Method**

In terms of content, this study synthesizes the results of prior research and treats the brand management factors proposed by five major domestic and foreign schools as potentially

affecting consumer perception as the initial variables. On the one hand, this prepares for building an initial variable pool in the later stage so that the effectiveness of each variable can be tested comprehensively and reliably. On the other hand, it provides an initial qualitative understanding of effectiveness so that appropriate hypotheses and models can be proposed in subsequent empirical analysis.

The literature review method has both advantages and disadvantages. Its advantage is comprehensiveness, as it integrates theories from different schools throughout the development of brand management research. Its disadvantage is complexity, because substantial resources must be invested in early-stage literature searching and integration.

## **2) Quantitative Analysis Method**

In terms of content, Stata is mainly used to conduct regression analysis, provide data support for the research conclusions, improve credibility and scientific rigor, and use different models to reduce error and verify the conclusions from multiple perspectives.

Quantitative analysis also has both advantages and disadvantages. Its advantage lies in presenting specific and accurate numerical results compared with qualitative conclusions. Its disadvantage is that experimental design, implementation, and analysis are relatively difficult and require substantial effort.

## **3) Empirical Research Method**

In terms of content, brand management in the international apparel industry is used as a concrete example to analyze the different effectiveness of its various management dimensions and provide specific and realistic case references for the industry and other enterprises.

The empirical research method likewise has both advantages and disadvantages. Its advantage is specificity: compared with analysis at the national level, it can examine strategies and tactics at the enterprise level, making it more relevant and transferable for contemporary Chinese small and medium-sized enterprises. Its disadvantage is the relatively narrow field. The selected brands are from the apparel industry, so the experience can be effectively extended to domestic Chinese apparel brands, but enterprises outside the apparel industry should selectively absorb and adapt it according to their own industry characteristics.

# **1.4 Main Innovations**

Building on the accumulated research of previous scholars, this study seeks to innovate in the following specific areas:

- 1) Screening brand management variables that affect consumer perception and narrowing the range of categories;
- 2) Applying quantitative analysis to provide data support;
- 3) Analyzing the specific effects of brand management on consumer perception.

## 2 Theoretical Background

### 2.1 Concept and Functions of a Brand

#### 2.1.1 Concept of a Brand

The professional use of the term “brand” was first introduced by Gardner and Levy (1955), who explained the emotional concept of a brand and brand personality in Product and Brand. The American Marketing Association (AMA) subsequently published an official definition of a brand: “A brand is a name, term, sign, symbol, design, or a combination of these elements, intended to identify the goods or services of one seller or group of sellers and to differentiate them from those of competitors” [24].

#### 2.1.2 Functions of a Brand

The functions of a brand are mainly reflected from the two perspectives of enterprises and consumers [25]:

For enterprises, a strong brand can maintain higher product prices, provide strong financial capacity, resist attacks from competitors, continuously create profits for the enterprise, and enhance corporate value.

For consumers, a brand can simplify purchase decisions, assure product quality, reduce purchase risk, and ultimately increase consumer trust and loyalty. In addition, brands also play an important role in the effectiveness of marketing elements such as advertising and distribution channels.

### 2.2 Brand Management and Its Factors

Brand management refers to the integrated management of the entire brand-building process. Through this process, brand operations can strongly support the overall operations of a company, continuously enhance the company’s core value and brand equity, and promote long-term development.

Brand management mainly consists of four major factors: brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing.

#### 2.2.1 Identifying and Determining Brand Positioning

The first step in brand management is brand positioning. Positioning theory was

pioneered by Ries and Trout (1979) [26] and developed by Kotler and Keller (2006) [27]. It refers to carefully designing a company's products, services, and image so that the brand occupies a distinctive and meaningful position in the minds of target customers. Brand positioning can determine the strategic direction of marketing programs and activities and define the scope of the brand's "activities" in the market. Its specific content includes market segmentation, target-market selection, and specific positioning.

At the same time, brand positioning is closely related to the brand's core values and brand language. On the one hand, core brand values are a set of abstract associations possessed by a brand and form the foundation of brand strategy. They play a fundamental role in brand positioning, especially in combining differentiation with commonality. On the other hand, a brand statement expresses the brand's core spirit and is usually regarded as the essence of the brand or its core promise. Generally, brand language is very short, often using only three to five words to describe the meaning of a corporate brand, its differentiated positioning, and the core of its brand values. Therefore, core brand values and brand wording can be regarded as the soul of the brand.

### **2.2.2 Brand Image Design**

Brand image refers to customers' perceptions of a brand as reflected in the brand associations held in their memory [28].

Brand image includes internal image and external image. The main components of the internal image are product image, MI conceptual identity, and BI behavioral identity, while the external image is mainly reflected in VI visual identity. Accordingly, a company's brand image design is also reflected in four areas: product image design, MI conceptual identity design, BI behavioral identity design, and VI visual identity design.

First, product image. Product image is the foundation of brand image and is related to the functional characteristics of the brand. Potential consumers' perception of a brand is first reflected in their perception of product characteristics. A brand is not empty; rather, it can satisfy consumers' physical and psychological needs, and this satisfaction is closely related to the product. If potential consumers have a strong favorable evaluation of and trust in a product, they will transfer that trust to the abstract brand, form a stronger favorable evaluation of the brand, and thereby develop a positive brand image.

Second, MI conceptual identity. Conceptual identity summarizes and elevates brand culture. The positioning of a brand concept must be accurate, concise, and clear in order to be recognizable. At the same time, both internal and external stakeholders must identify with the brand culture, and the concept must be internalized into actual behavior before external social recognition can be obtained.

Third, BI behavioral identity. Behavioral identity refers to the standardized criteria that a brand should follow in internal coordination and external communication. These criteria are reflected in the consistent daily behavior of all employees. In other words, all employee behavior within a company should constitute corporate behavior that reflects the company's business philosophy and values, rather than independent and arbitrary individual behavior. Compared with ordinary rules and regulations, behavioral identity places greater emphasis on using rules to form mechanisms that stimulate organizational vitality, and such mechanisms must be distinctive, creative, and recognizable.

Fourth, VI visual identity. Visual identity refers to using visual communication design techniques, under the guidance of the company's management philosophy, to visualize the enterprise's inner spirit and its position in the market. It reflects the company's differentiation. It mainly includes two parts: a basic system for design concepts and an application system for implementing the design. The basic system includes the company and brand logos, standard corporate typefaces, standard corporate colors, basic combination specifications, and combinations of standard brand typefaces. The application system covers transaction identification systems, activity identification systems, product packaging identification systems, advertising identification systems, and environmental identification systems.

### **2.2.3 Brand Extension**

Tauber first proposed brand extension in *Extending Brand Approval: New Products from Older Brands* [29] in 1979. Brand extension refers to using a brand that already has a certain degree of awareness and market influence as a starting point to extend an existing product line into new businesses or product lines; it can also involve multiple companies or products sharing the same brand.

Kevin Lane Keller argued that brand extensions can be broadly divided into two types [30]: line extensions and category extensions. First, a line extension uses the parent brand to

develop a new product for a new segment within the original product category. Second, a category extension means that the parent brand moves from its original product category into another category.

In addition, brand internationalization is also a major form of extension. Products may be at different stages of their life cycles in different regions and countries, and they may also have different perceptions and positioning across locations. Therefore, one key to successful global brand promotion is identifying and using the behavioral habits of local consumers. When entering a new market, a comprehensive understanding of consumer behavior characteristics is crucial to the success or failure of a brand. The best global brands usually formulate their marketing-mix strategies according to different consumer behaviors and competitive conditions in each country or region. Such strategies generally do not change the core of the brand but adjust certain elements so as to maximize the strengths, address the weaknesses, increase brand awareness, and build a positive brand image in each country where the company's products are sold, thereby creating strong, favorable, and differentiated brand associations.

#### **2.2.4 Brand Marketing**

Brand marketing is the process through which customers form perceptions of a company's brand and products through marketing.

Brand marketing includes four main components: brand personality, brand communication, brand sales, and brand building. First, brand personality refers to a set of personality characteristics assigned to a brand (J. Aaker, 1997) [31], including the brand name, packaging design, product price, brand concept, brand spokesperson, image style, and suitable customer groups. Second, brand communication includes advertising style, communication targets, media techniques, advertising and promotion, public relations, word-of-mouth image, and point-of-sale displays. Third, brand sales include channel strategy, personal selling, salesperson promotion, advertising promotion, event marketing, and incentives. Finally, brand building involves team building, marketing systems, brand maintenance, terminal development, ethical incentives, channel management, and dealer management.

In addition, experiential marketing is one of the most important marketing concepts and trends today. Park et al. (1986) argued that the value of a brand to consumers can be divided

into three categories [32]: functional value, symbolic value, and experiential value. Experiential value can satisfy consumers' needs for sensory gratification, variety, and cognitive stimulation. Therefore, Schmitt (1999 and 2003) advocated the concept and importance of customer experience management at the strategic level and pointed out that the customer's product experience process should be managed strategically. He argued that brands can create five types of experiences for consumers: sensory, affective, intellectual, behavioral, and relational experiences.

## **2.3 Consumer Perception and Its Factors**

Consumer perception refers to consumers' immediate reactions when they encounter a brand or product. It has rich connotations, including consumer brand awareness, consumer brand attitude, and consumer purchase intention.

### **2.3.1 Brand Awareness**

Brand awareness refers to the extent to which consumers know a brand and reflects the degree or breadth of the brand's influence.

Brand awareness has three levels from low to high. First, brand recognition means that consumers can identify a brand on the basis of cues, thereby developing familiarity. Second, brand recall means that consumers can independently remember brands within a product category without prompts from others. Third, top-of-mind awareness means that the brand occupies a higher position in consumers' minds than other brands in the same field and therefore possesses a strong competitive advantage.

### **2.3.2 Brand Attitude**

Brand attitude refers to consumers' habitual tendency, formed through learning and reinforcement, to respond to a brand with liking or dislike. It represents consumers' overall evaluation of the brand and is the most abstract and highest-level form of brand association.

Brand attitude has both consistency and variability. It is relatively stable during a particular stage for consumers, but it can also change because attitude is essentially a learned tendency and consumers may display different attitudes in different situations.

An important indicator of brand attitude is brand loyalty. This means that consumers repeatedly purchase and use a brand over a long period of time and develop a certain degree

of trust, commitment, emotional attachment, and even emotional dependence on the brand [33]. Brand-loyal customers are less sensitive to price, are willing to pay a premium for high quality, identify with the brand's values, regard the brand as a friend and partner, and contribute to the brand.

### **2.3.3 Purchase Intention**

Purchase intention refers to the probability that consumers are willing to adopt a specific purchasing behavior.

The consumer purchasing mechanism involves multiple steps, such as problem recognition, information search, alternative evaluation, purchase decision, and post-purchase behavior, while purchase intention is formed at the purchase-decision stage. Consumers form purchase intentions and preferences among different alternatives before carrying out the purchase.

It is important to distinguish purchase intention from purchase behavior. Purchase intention remains within the theoretical scope of consumer perception and reflects only the likelihood that consumers will purchase a product. Purchase behavior, by contrast, belongs to the field of consumer behavior and objectively describes the outcome of consumption. Having purchase intention does not necessarily lead to purchase behavior because many other factors intervene between intention and behavior, such as the opinions of others, social pressure, and consumers' spending levels.

## **2.4 International Apparel Industry**

The apparel industry refers to the industry that produces clothing products by manufacturing and processing various natural or synthetic polymer materials such as hemp, cotton, fabrics, and chemical fibers. The international apparel industry refers to the industrial cluster formed by enterprises whose production and sales activities span global markets.

The history of the apparel industry originated in Europe. In the mid-nineteenth century, the earliest professional fashion designers appeared in France. In 1858, Charles Frederick Worth established his own fashion house on Rue de la Paix, creating his own clothing, design, production, and professional practice. His studio was the world's first fashion design studio and adopted a series of distinctive operating methods, such as presenting collections, thereby

forming the prototype of today's Paris haute couture industry.

Finally, apparel operations consist of three major links - research and development and design, processing and production, and brand and channel operations - forming a "smile curve" profit model. First, research and development and design differ from many other industries because design is the core of the entire process and also the most challenging and creative stage; the quality of design strongly affects subsequent sales. Second, processing and production are mainly undertaken through subcontracting, with tasks delegated to cooperating factories and enterprises; profit growth in this stage is relatively low. Third, brand and channel operations include brand management, channel governance, and relationship management. This is the stage in which products connect directly with consumers and it generates relatively high value growth.

## 3 Research Hypotheses and Models

### 3.1 Research Hypotheses

#### 3.1.1 Related Research Hypotheses

The preceding literature review summarized five major domestic and foreign schools and more than twenty types of theories. Although there are many theories, their hypotheses can generally be classified into the following fixed categories:

##### 1) Brand positioning factor

This category is represented by Jack Trout and Al Ries's positioning theory and emphasizes the effect of brand market positioning on consumer perception.

##### 2) Brand image factor

This category is represented by the brand semiotics school and focuses on the influence of visual symbols on consumer perception. In particular, Brand Identity theory, represented by J. N. Kapferer and Aaker, emphasizes the role of brand logos in consumer visual identification. The brand image theories of S. J. Levy and B. B. Gardner and C. W. Park's three-dimensional brand concept extend simple brand symbols into deeper intrinsic brand value and perceptions of the parent company's image. The USP theories of Rosser Reeves and Bates emphasize the uniqueness of brand image, while the personality theories of Grey, Kobayashi, and J. Aaker highlight brand personality.

##### 3) Brand marketing factor

A typical representative is the brand marketing school, which emphasizes the influence of marketing strategies on consumer perception. David Ogilvy's brand image theory innovatively stressed the importance of advertising. S. Fournier's consumer-brand relationship theory focuses on multilateral interactions in the marketing process, while A. M. Muniz's brand community theory responds to the development of the internet era and proposes the leading role of social media and communities. In addition, the brand information school also emphasizes the effects of information and information processing in marketing on consumer perception, with Schmitt's experiential marketing theory as a major representative.

##### 4) Multiple factors

The first is the brand equity school. Because brand equity involves financial assets, market share, consumer evaluation, and other dimensions, this school emphasizes the combined effects of multiple factors such as brand market positioning, brand image, and brand marketing. Its main representatives are David A. Aaker's brand equity theory and Five-Star Model and Keller's customer-based brand equity theory.

The second is the brand strategy school, which emphasizes systematic management. Neil McElroy and David A. Aaker's brand leadership theories involve the business and organizational dimensions of brand management. Ogilvy's Brand Stewardship and 360-Degree Brand Management theories and Tom Duncan and Sandra Moriarty's integrated marketing and communication interaction theory emphasize the consumer-brand relationship dimension of brand marketing, while Paul Temporal's role-transition theory focuses on the role of the parent company's image in consumer perception.

In summary, the research hypotheses of the preceding scholars are mainly concentrated on brand positioning factors, brand image factors, brand marketing factors, and the joint effects of these factors.

### **3.1.2 Research Hypotheses of This Study**

On the basis of previous theoretical research and hypotheses, this study examines the effects of the following factors on consumer perception: brand positioning, brand image, brand marketing, and brand extension.

The purpose of the first three factors is to test the validity of the hypotheses proposed by previous scholars. The fourth factor, brand extension, is a new factor added in this study in response to the widespread internationalization and establishment of multinational companies in the twenty-first century.

Accordingly, the research content and hypotheses of this study are as follows:

#### **1) Relationship between brand management and consumer perception**

Question: Does brand management affect consumer perception?

Hypothesis:

H1: Brand management (X) is unrelated to consumer perception.

#### **2) Relationship between the four components of brand management - brand**

positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing - **and consumer perception**

Question: Do brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing affect consumer perception?

Hypotheses:

H2: Brand positioning (X) is unrelated to consumer perception (Y).

H3: Brand image (X) is unrelated to consumer perception (Y).

H4: Brand extension (X) is unrelated to consumer perception (Y).

H5: Brand marketing (X) is unrelated to consumer perception (Y).

**3) Relationship between the four components of brand management** - brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing - **and the three components of consumer perception** - consumer brand awareness, consumer brand attitude, and consumer purchase intention

(1) Question: Do brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing affect consumer brand awareness?

Hypotheses:

H6: Brand positioning (X) is unrelated to consumer brand awareness (Y).

H7: Brand image (X) is unrelated to consumer brand awareness (Y).

H8: Brand extension (X) is unrelated to consumer brand awareness (Y).

H9: Brand marketing (X) is unrelated to consumer brand awareness (Y).

Question: Do brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing affect consumer brand attitude?

Hypotheses:

H10: Brand positioning (X) is unrelated to consumer brand attitude (Y).

H11: Brand image (X) is unrelated to consumer brand attitude (Y).

H12: Brand extension (X) is unrelated to consumer brand attitude (Y).

H13: Brand marketing (X) is unrelated to consumer brand attitude (Y).

Question: Do brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing affect consumer purchase intention?

Hypotheses:

H14: Brand positioning (X) is unrelated to consumer purchase intention (Y).

H15: Brand image (X) is unrelated to consumer purchase intention (Y).

H16: Brand extension (X) is unrelated to consumer purchase intention (Y).

H17: Brand marketing (X) is unrelated to consumer purchase intention (Y).

**4) Extended analysis in this study: relationship between brand management and its four components, namely brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing**

Question: How large are the effects of brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing on brand management? Which approach to brand management is the most effective?

Hypotheses:

H18: Brand positioning (X) is unrelated to brand management (Y).

H19: Brand image (X) is unrelated to brand management (Y).

H20: Brand extension (X) is unrelated to brand management (Y).

H21: Brand marketing (X) is unrelated to brand management (Y).

Note: X denotes the independent variable and Y denotes the dependent variable.

## 3.2 Research Models

### 3.2.1 Stata Regression Model

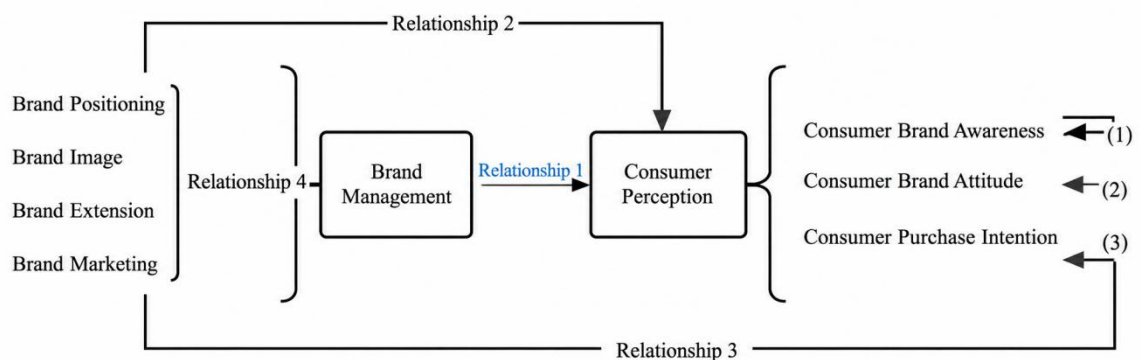


Figure 3-1 Model of the Effect of Brand Management on Consumer Perception

This model involves four major themes and six regression-relationship analyses.

This study uses the correlation analysis module in Stata 15.0 and examines the

correlations between independent and dependent variables through six regression analyses. First, because the independent variables in reg regression must be numerical or categorical variables and the dependent variable must be numerical, and both the independent and dependent variables in this study are numerical variables, the reg regression method is used. Second, the study examines linear correlations among variables and therefore does not include nonlinear relationships. The basic formula is:

$$Y=aX_1+bX_2+cX_3+\dots$$

(3-2-1)

Regarding sample selection, the analysis is based on data across different dimensions for 30 international apparel brands and one industry average; detailed brand information is provided later. First, the international apparel industry is selected because this is consistent with the study's objective of examining the global apparel industry and providing suggestions for the development of China's apparel sector. Second, the sample size is 31. (1) According to the minimum-sample-size rule in statistics [34],  $n > k + 1$  is required, where  $n$  is the sample size and  $k$  is the number of explanatory variables. Because the maximum number of explanatory variables in the six regression analyses is four,  $31 > 4$  satisfies this requirement. (2) According to the effective-sample theorem,  $n > 30$  (which can be regarded as a large sample in statistics) or  $n > 3 \times (k + 1)$  is required. Because  $31 > 30$  and  $31 > 15$ , this requirement is satisfied. (3) Given a 95% confidence level, the relevant confidence interval, and a total population of 700 brands, calculation shows that the minimum sample-size requirement of 30 is satisfied.

The analytical procedure of this study is as follows:

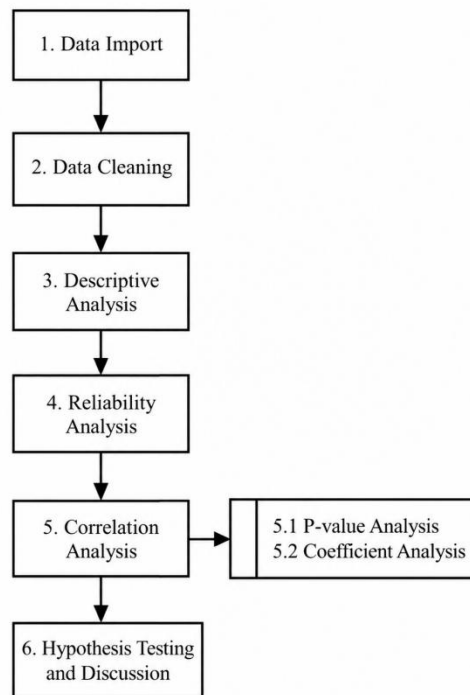


Figure 3-2 Research Procedure

### 3.2.2 Interbrand Model - Quantitative Evaluation of Brand Management Effectiveness

The Interbrand model is a method for evaluating corporate brand value developed by Interbrand in London, United Kingdom [35], and is currently one of the most influential methods worldwide. Its basic premise is that effective brand management creates brand value. Therefore, brand value is an effective indicator for evaluating brand management, and brand value originates from the stable future earnings that a brand can bring to users.

#### 1) Content

The model includes three areas of analysis: financial analysis, market analysis, and brand analysis. Financial analysis is used to estimate residual profits from products or businesses, where residual profits reflect intangible assets, including all profits created by the brand. Market analysis is used to determine the role of the brand within the valuable product category or industry in which it operates; the “Role of Brand Index” method evaluates the percentage of revenue generated by brand-related intangible assets and is used to derive brand-related earnings. Brand analysis evaluates the brand strength

of the target company, determines the rated brand's relative position compared with other brands in the same industry, and describes the risk associated with the brand's ability to generate future profits.

## 2) Calculation Method

The Interbrand model is calculated using the following formula:

$$V=P*S$$

(3-2-2)

V: brand value

P: brand earnings

S: brand multiplier

Here, P, brand earnings, is the weighted average after-tax net profit of the brand over the most recent three years.

$$P = \frac{\text{After-tax net profit}_i * 3 + \text{After-tax net profit}_{i-1} * 2 + \text{After-tax net profit}_{i-3}}{6}$$

(3-2-3)

S, the brand multiplier, is a multiplier related to brand strength developed in the Interbrand model. The brand multiplier and brand strength have the following functional relationship:

$$250y = x^2, \quad x \in [0, 50]$$

(3-2-4)

$$(y - 10)^2 = 2x - 100, \quad x \in (50, 100]$$

(3-2-5)

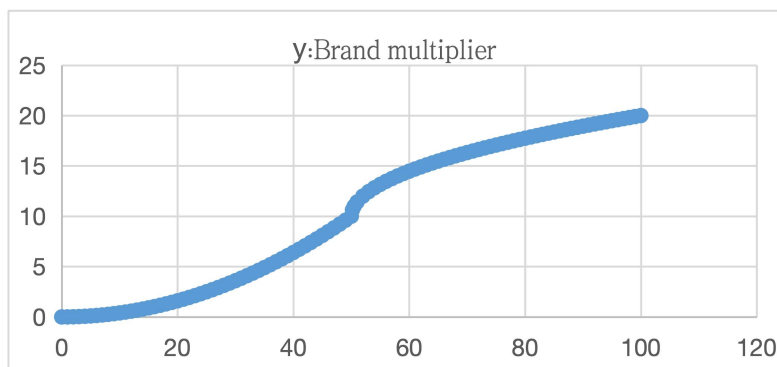


Figure 3-3 S-Curve of the Brand Multiplier

Brand strength is determined by seven indicators with different weights:

Table 3-1 Seven Indicators Affecting Brand Strength

| Factor                 | Description                                      | Weight |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Support                | Degree of sustained brand investment and support | 10%    |
| Brand Protection       | Degree of brand protection                       | 5%     |
| Leadership             | Brand market position                            | 25%    |
| Stability              | Brand history                                    | 15%    |
| Market Status          | Nature of the market in which the brand operates | 10%    |
| International Presence | Geographic scope of brand marketing              | 25%    |
| Brand Trend            | Direction of brand development                   | 10%    |

### 3) Model Evaluation

The Interbrand model plays a leading role in the fields of brand management and brand value evaluation and has the following main advantages. First, it quantifies the effects of brand management using data. Second, it evaluates multiple dimensions, including finance, market, and brand, making it rational, scientific, and relatively reliable. Third, the relevant formulas, curves, and weights were proposed on the basis of extensive research and validation and therefore have high reliability and validity.

However, the Interbrand model also has some shortcomings. Although the weights used to determine brand strength are based on data analysis, the weights of the seven factors may vary under different circumstances; therefore, simply fixing the weights is relatively crude.

### 3.2.3 HIROSE Model - Quantitative Evaluation of Consumer Perception

The HIROSE model was proposed by the Brand Valuation Committee represented by Yoshikuni Hirose [36]. It holds that consumer perception is mainly affected by consumer brand awareness, brand loyalty, and purchase intention, and that measuring these three factors can produce an overall quantitative score of consumer perception.

#### 1) Content

##### (1) Expansion Driver (ED) - Evaluating Brand Awareness

The expansion driver refers to the scale and reach of a brand and reflects consumers'

brand awareness.

## (2) Loyalty Driver (LD) - Evaluating Brand Attitude

Loyalty refers to the degree of consumer trust in a brand and can affect the brand's long-term development.

## (3) Price Driver (PD) - Evaluating Purchase Intention

The price driver refers to the extent to which consumers' willingness to purchase a brand increases under the influence of price factors. Because the HIROSE model assumes that brand price plays an important role in consumer purchase decisions, price is strongly reflected in this driver.

## 2) Calculation Method

The Expansion Driver (ED) is the average of the growth rate of the brand's overseas sales and the growth rate of non-core-business sales over the most recent three years:

$$ED = \frac{1}{2} \left\{ \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=-1}^0 \left( \frac{SO_i - SO_{i-1}}{SO_{i-1}} + 1 \right) + \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=-1}^0 \frac{SX_i - SX_{i-1}}{SX_{i-1}} + 1 \right\}$$

(3-2-6)

SO: overseas sales

SX: non-core-business sales

The Loyalty Driver (LD) is calculated by subtracting the standard deviation of sales costs from the average sales costs over the most recent five years and dividing the result by the average sales costs over the most recent five years:

$$LD = \frac{\mu_c - \sigma_c}{\mu_c}$$

(3-2-7)

$\mu_c$  Average sales cost over the most recent five years

$\sigma_c$  Standard deviation of sales cost

The Price Driver (PD) is the product of the excess profit margin, brand contribution rate, and sales cost, namely:

$$PD = \frac{1}{5} \sum_{i=-4}^0 \left\{ \left( \frac{S_i}{c_i} - \frac{S_i^*}{c_i^*} \right) * \frac{A_i}{OE_i} \right\} * C_0$$

(3-2-8)

S: brand sales

S\*: benchmark-brand sales

C: brand cost of sales

C\*: benchmark-brand cost of sales

A: brand advertising and promotional expenses

OE: brand operating expenses

$\text{Min} \frac{\text{Sales}}{\text{Cost of sales}}$  Here, the benchmark enterprise refers to the brand in the industry with

the lowest sales per unit of cost of sales, that is, the brand corresponding to the relevant minimum value.

### 3) Model Evaluation

The HIROSE model is widely recognized in industry as a relatively complete and comprehensive model for evaluating consumer perception and has the following advantages. First, its three major drivers fit closely with the components of consumer perception and can effectively reflect evaluation results for the three major dimensions of consumer perception. Second, it fully quantifies each factor and is therefore highly objective. Third, the model analyzes the issue from both consumer and enterprise perspectives and is thus more comprehensive than models based on only one side.

## 4 Experimental Design, Implementation, and Analysis

### 4.1 Data Sources

#### 4.1.1 Data Sources for Brand Management Indicators

**1) Data for the four components of brand management:** brand positioning, brand image, brand extension, and brand marketing

(1) Statista Global Consumer Survey 2021

The above data are based on Statista's Global Consumer Survey conducted worldwide in 2021 [37]. In terms of breadth, the survey covered 56 countries, 3.4 billion consumers, and 115,000 brands. In terms of depth, Statista conducted more than one million consumer interviews, and its 61-page, 274-question survey covered personal information, financial information, brand recognition, style perceptions, price perceptions, brand identification, brand experience, brand purchase intention, internet and devices, social media, and other topics.

(2) Statista Brand Performance Check Guide

On the basis of the global survey described above, Statista also used its Brand Performance Check Guide [38] to classify and quantify factors under the four major brand management indicators as follows:

1. Brand positioning: comprehensively scored on the basis of industry size, number of consumers, gender, age, per-capita expenditure, number of industry competitors, and other factors.

2. Brand image: comprehensively scored on the basis of parent-company revenue and profit, earnings per share, number of store employees, corporate culture, brand revenue and profit, brand history, brand logo and colors, consumer awareness, and other factors.

3. Brand extension: comprehensively scored on the basis of the number of product categories extended by the brand, sub-brands, degree of internationalization, brand collaborations, and other factors.

4. Brand marketing: comprehensively scored on the basis of brand style, pricing strategy, distribution strategy, advertising expenditure, social-media communication

strategy, and other factors.

## **2) Data for the Overall Brand Management Score**

Brand management value evaluation based on the Interbrand model has two major data requirements: after-tax net profit, which affects brand earnings, and the seven brand-strength indicators, which affect the brand multiplier. Their sources are as follows:

1. Company annual reports

After-tax net profit can be found in the income statement.

2. Statista Global Consumer Survey 2021

As described above, the consumer survey measures consumers' perceptions of brand support, protection, leadership, stability, market conditions, internationalization, and development trends.

### **4.1.2 Data Sources for Consumer Perception Indicators**

Because the HIROSE model is used for quantification, all required data can be obtained from companies' annual reports, including income statements, balance sheets, stock analyses, and related materials.

#### **\*Notes on Financial Reports:**

A company annual report refers to the report for the parent company's "fiscal year," meaning that the reporting date is not necessarily the final day of the calendar year.

Company financial reports include both consolidated statements for the company as a whole and separate statements for relevant subsidiary brands, facilitating data retrieval.

Currency conversion. Different companies report in different currencies, mainly U.S. dollars and euros. For ease of calculation, all currencies are converted into U.S. dollars. Because fiscal-year reports are used, the market exchange rate on the date the company's annual report was published is applied.

### **4.1.3 Basic Sample Information**

The sample collected by Statista's Global Consumer Survey 2021 [39] is broad and scientifically designed, providing a solid foundation for this study. The following presents the basic sample statistics:

Table 4-1-1 Sample Countries, Sample Sizes, and Age Proportions

| Country:territory  | No. of respondents | Quotas on gender | Quotas on age                       |
|--------------------|--------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------|
|                    |                    | Male : Female    | 18-24;25-34; 35-44; 45-54;<br>55-64 |
| Argentina          | 2,100              | 49:51            | 21:28:24:17:10                      |
| Australia          | 3,150              | 50:50            | 15:25:23:20:16                      |
| Austria            | 3,150              | 50:50            | 13:23:22:23:20                      |
| Belgium            | 2,100              | 50:50            | 14:22:22:22:20                      |
| Brazil             | 3,150              | 49:51            | 20:28:26:17:8                       |
| Canada             | 3,150              | 50:50            | 14:24:22:20:20                      |
| Chile              | 2,100              | 50:50            | 17:27:23:19:14                      |
| Mainland China     | 6,300              | 52:48            | 18:32:25:21:4                       |
| Colombia           | 2,100              | 49:51            | 23 : 30 : 24 : 16 : 7               |
| Czechia            | 2,100              | 51:49            | 11:21:27:24:17                      |
| Denmark            | 2,100              | 50:50            | 15:22:19:23:21                      |
| Dominican Republic | 2,100              | 50:50            | 23:29:23:16:9                       |
| Egypt              | 2,100              | 57:43            | 26:34:25:12:3                       |
| Finland            | 3,150              | 50:50            | 14:22:22:20:22                      |
| France             | 3,150              | 49:51            | 14:21:22:23:19                      |
| Germany            | 6,300              | 53:47            | 12:21:21:23:23                      |
| Greece             | 2,100              | 50:50            | 14:20:26:24:16                      |
| Hong Kong          | 2,100              | 47:53            | 11:21:23:23:22                      |
| Hungary            | 2,100              | 48:52            | 13:22:26:23:15                      |
| India              | 6,300              | 60:40            | 31:38:26:5:0                        |
| Indonesia          | 2,100              | 53:47            | 27:32:28:13:0                       |
| Ireland            | 2,100              | 49:51            | 15:20:27:22:15                      |
| Israel             | 2,100              | 51:49            | 20:25:24:19:13                      |
| Italy              | 3,150              | 50:50            | 13:19:23:26:20                      |
| Japan              | 2,100              | 46:54            | 13:20:24:26:18                      |

|                               |       |       |                |
|-------------------------------|-------|-------|----------------|
| Kenya                         | 2,100 | 62:38 | 41:39:20:0:0   |
| Korea (Republic of)           | 3,150 | 51:49 | 13:20:23:25:21 |
| Lithuania                     | 2,100 | 46:54 | 12:25:20:22:20 |
| Malaysia                      | 2,100 | 53:47 | 20:29:24:16:10 |
| Mexico                        | 3,150 | 50:50 | 22:29:24:17:8  |
| Morocco                       | 2,100 | 52:48 | 20:29:24:16:10 |
| Netherlands                   | 3,150 | 50:50 | 14:21:19:23:23 |
| New Zealand                   | 2,100 | 50:50 | 16:24:20:21:18 |
| Nigeria                       | 2,100 | 59:41 | 36:35:22:7:0   |
| Norway                        | 2,100 | 50:50 | 14:22:21:23:19 |
| Pakistan                      | 2,100 | 71:29 | 40:41:18:0:0   |
| Peru                          | 2,100 | 52:48 | 22:32:26:15:   |
| Philippines                   | 2,100 | 52:48 | 31:36:24:9:0   |
| Poland                        | 3,150 | 49:51 | 13:25:28:19:15 |
| Portugal                      | 2,100 | 48:52 | 14:21:26:23:16 |
| Romania                       | 2,100 | 49:51 | 14:23:25:24:14 |
| Russian Federation            | 3,150 | 47:53 | 11:25:26:19:18 |
| Saudi Arabia                  | 2,100 | 59:41 | 14:28:30:20:8  |
| Serbia                        | 2,100 | 51:49 | 15:24:25:21:15 |
| Singapore                     | 2,100 | 53:47 | 13:22:23:23:19 |
| South Africa                  | 3,150 | 49:51 | 24:35:26:12:3  |
| Spain                         | 3,150 | 49:51 | 11:18:26:26:20 |
| Sweden                        | 3,150 | 49:51 | 13:24:21:22:20 |
| Switzerland                   | 3,150 | 50:50 | 12:21:22:23:21 |
| Taiwan (Province of<br>China) | 2,100 | 46:54 | 12:22:23:23:19 |
| Thailand                      | 2,100 | 49:51 | 18:24:25:22:12 |
| Turkey                        | 2,100 | 54:46 | 21:28:26:17:8  |
| United Arab Emirates          | 2,100 | 69:31 | 11:40:28:14:6  |

|                          |        |       |                |
|--------------------------|--------|-------|----------------|
| United Kingdom           | 3,150  | 49:51 | 14:23:22:22:19 |
| United States of America | 11,025 | 49:51 | 16:24:21:20:19 |
| Vietnam                  | 2,100  | 51:49 | 18:31:25:17:9  |

Table 4-1-2 Sample Income Proportions

| Proportion | Total Household Income (USD/year) |
|------------|-----------------------------------|
| 33%        | 0-45,000                          |
| 33%        | 45,000-80,000                     |
| 24%        | 80,000-145,000                    |
| 10%        | 145,000-300,000                   |

#### 4.1.4 Basic Brand Information

The following presents the names and statistical information of the sampled brands:

Table 4-1-3 Brand List

| No. | Brand Name      |
|-----|-----------------|
| 1   | The North Face  |
| 2   | Timberland      |
| 3   | Vans            |
| 4   | Napapijki       |
| 5   | Jansport        |
| 6   | Supreme         |
| 7   | Rock & Republic |
| 8   | Dickies         |
| 9   | Lee             |
| 10  | Wangler         |
| 11  | Christian Dior  |
| 12  | EMilio Pucci    |
| 13  | Fendi           |
| 14  | Loewe           |
| 15  | Loro Piana      |

|    |                    |
|----|--------------------|
| 16 | Louis Vuitton      |
| 17 | Marc Jacobs        |
| 18 | Alexander McQueen  |
| 19 | Balenciaga         |
| 20 | Bottega Veneta     |
| 21 | Gucci              |
| 22 | Yves Saint Laurent |
| 23 | Zara               |
| 24 | Bershka            |
| 25 | Massimo Dutti      |
| 26 | Oysho              |
| 27 | Pull and Bear      |
| 28 | Stradivarius       |
| 29 | Michael Kors       |
| 30 | Versace            |

Table 4-1-4 Basic Brand Information

| Dimension                        |  | Category            | Proportion |
|----------------------------------|--|---------------------|------------|
| Public Company Status            |  | Listed              | 46.67%     |
|                                  |  | Unlisted            | 53.33%     |
| Brand Tier                       |  | Mass-market apparel | 30%        |
|                                  |  | Fashion apparel     | 23.33%     |
|                                  |  | Luxury apparel      | 46.67%     |
|                                  |  | 0-100               | 23.33%     |
| Average Brand Price (USD)        |  | 100-300             | 30%        |
|                                  |  | 300-1500            | 30%        |
|                                  |  | 1500-5000           | 13.33%     |
|                                  |  | 5000-50000          | 3.33%      |
| Brand Revenue (USD million/year) |  | 0-1000              | 30%        |
|                                  |  | 1000-1500           | 16.67%     |

|              |           |        |
|--------------|-----------|--------|
|              | 1500-5000 | 43.33% |
|              | 5000+     | 10%    |
|              | 0%-0.5%   | 23.33% |
|              | 0.5%-2%   | 26.67% |
| Market Share | 2%-5%     | 40%    |
|              | 5%+       | 10%    |

## 4.2 Data Analysis and Results

### 4.2.1 Validity Analysis

Validity refers to the extent to which data measure what they are intended to measure and reflects the accuracy of a test.

This study uses Bartlett's test of sphericity to test whether the correlation matrix is an identity matrix, that is, whether the variables are independent. The null hypothesis is that the correlation coefficient matrix is an identity matrix. At the 95% significance level, if  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and the correlation matrix is considered not to be an identity matrix, indicating that factor analysis can be conducted; conversely, if  $p > 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is accepted and the data are considered unsuitable for factor analysis.

#### 4.2.1.1 Relationship between Brand Management and Consumer Perception

Because  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and factor analysis is appropriate.

#### 4.2.1.2 Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Perception

Because  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and factor analysis is appropriate.

#### 4.2.1.3 Relationship between the Four Components of Brand Management - Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand Marketing - and the Three Components of Consumer Perception - Consumer Brand Awareness, Consumer Brand Attitude, and Consumer Purchase Intention

1) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Awareness

Because  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and factor analysis is appropriate.

2) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Attitude

Because  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and factor analysis is appropriate.

3) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Purchase Intention

Because  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and factor analysis is appropriate.

#### **4.2.1.4 Relationship between Brand Management and Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand Marketing**

Because  $p < 0.05$ , the null hypothesis is rejected and factor analysis is appropriate.

#### **4.2.2 Reliability Analysis**

Reliability refers to the extent to which a testing method is unaffected by random error and reflects the consistency and stability of test results.

Because the variables in this study are continuous variables, the ICC (Intraclass Correlation Coefficient) proposed by Ronald Fisher (1954) is used to measure test-retest reliability. ICC reliability  $> 0.75$  indicates excellent reliability, while ICC reliability in  $[0.6, 0.75]$  indicates good reliability. The results are as follows:

##### **4.2.2.1 Relationship between Brand Management and Consumer Perception**

The reliability between brand management and consumer perception is 0.6637, indicating good reliability.

##### **4.2.2.2 Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Perception**

The reliability between brand positioning and consumer perception is 0.6348, indicating good reliability; between brand image and consumer perception, 0.5505, indicating moderate reliability; between brand extension and consumer perception, 0.1063, indicating poor reliability; and between brand marketing and consumer perception, 0.7999, indicating excellent reliability.

##### **4.2.2.3 Relationship between the Four Components of Brand Management - Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand**

## Marketing - and the Three Components of Consumer Perception - Consumer Brand Awareness, Consumer Brand Attitude, and Consumer Purchase Intention

### 1) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Awareness

The reliability between brand positioning and consumer brand awareness is 0.5481, indicating moderate reliability; between brand image and consumer brand awareness, 0.2457, indicating poor reliability; between brand extension and consumer brand awareness, 0.2310, indicating poor reliability; and between brand marketing and consumer brand awareness, 0.8716, indicating excellent reliability.

### 2) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Attitude

The reliability between brand positioning and consumer brand attitude is 0.2556, indicating poor reliability; between brand image and consumer brand attitude, 0.7487, indicating good reliability; between brand extension and consumer brand attitude, 0.0253, indicating poor reliability; and between brand marketing and consumer brand attitude, 0.3195, indicating moderate reliability.

### 3) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Purchase Intention

The reliability between brand positioning and consumer purchase intention is 0.5674, indicating moderate reliability; between brand image and consumer purchase intention, 0.6974, indicating good reliability; between brand extension and consumer purchase intention, 0.0745, indicating poor reliability; and between brand marketing and consumer purchase intention, 0.0054, indicating poor reliability.

## 4.2.2.4 Relationship between Brand Management and Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand Marketing

The reliability between brand positioning and brand management is 0.3685, indicating moderate reliability; between brand image and brand management, 0.3685, indicating moderate reliability; between brand extension and brand management, 0.1361, indicating poor reliability; and between brand marketing and brand management, 0.9428, indicating excellent

reliability.

### 4.2.3 Regression Analysis

#### 4.2.3.1 Relationship between Brand Management and Consumer Perception

First, the results are as follows:

Table 4-2-3-1

| Y: Consumer Perception | Coefficient | Standard Error | P-value (95% CI)                  |
|------------------------|-------------|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| X: Brand Management    | 2.230755    | 0.4668106      | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| _cons Constant         | 1186.868    | 655.9404       | 0.081                             |

Therefore, the empirical results show that brand management has a significant positive effect on consumer perception.

#### 4.2.3.2 Relationship between the Four Components of Brand Management - Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand Marketing - and Consumer Perception

First, the results are as follows:

Table 4-2-3-2

| Y: Consumer Perception | Coefficient | Standard Error | P-value (95% CI) |
|------------------------|-------------|----------------|------------------|
| X1: Brand Positioning  | 0.066748    | 0.0303794      | 0.037            |
| X2: Brand Image        | 0.1084275   | 0.0793777      | 0.184            |
| X3: Brand Extension    | -8.021378   | 25.36104       | 0.754            |
| X4: Brand Marketing    | 7.832343    | 1.987196       | 0.001            |
| _cons Constant         | -2421.746   | 1129.36        | 0.041            |

Therefore, the empirical results show that brand positioning and brand marketing have positive effects on consumer perception. Brand marketing has the most significant effect on improving consumer perception: for every one-unit increase in brand marketing, the consumer perception score increases by 7.832343 units.

#### 4.2.3.3 Relationship between the Four Components of Brand Management - Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand Marketing - and the Three Components of Consumer Perception - Consumer Brand Awareness, Consumer Brand Attitude, and Consumer

## Purchase Intention

### 1) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Awareness

First, the results are as follows:

Table 4-2-3-3-1

| Y: ED Expansion Driver<br>(Consumer Brand Awareness) | Coefficient | Standard Error | P-value (95% CI)                  |
|------------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| X1: Brand Positioning                                | 0.0000401   | 9.19e-6        | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| X2: Brand Image                                      | -0.0000299  | 0.0000244      | 0.232                             |
| X3: Brand Extension                                  | 0.0078708   | 0.0085845      | 0.368                             |
| X4: Brand Marketing                                  | 0.0052111   | 0.0004982      | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| _cons Constant                                       | -0.1976356  | 0.3612639      | 0.0589                            |

Therefore, the empirical results show that brand positioning and brand marketing have significant positive effects on consumer brand awareness.

### 2) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Attitude

First, the results are as follows:

Table 4-2-3-3-2

| Y: LD Loyalty Driver<br>(Consumer Brand Attitude) | Coefficient | Standard Error | P-value (95% CI)                  |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| X1: Brand Positioning                             | 2e-8        | 1.98e-7        | 0.921                             |
| X2: Brand Image                                   | 2.74e-6     | 5.47e-7        | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| X3: Brand Extension                               | -0.000076   | 0.0001853      | 0.685                             |
| X4: Brand Marketing                               | 9.06e-6     | 0.0000108      | 0.407                             |
| _cons Constant                                    | 0.8378477   | 0.0077982      | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |

Therefore, the empirical results show that brand image has a significant positive effect on consumer brand attitude.

### 3) Relationship between Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand

## Marketing, and Consumer Purchase Intention

First, the results are as follows:

Table 4-2-3-3-2

| Y: PD Price Driver<br>(Consumer Purchase Intention) | Coefficient | Standard Error | P-value (95% CI)                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| X1: Brand Positioning                               | 0.002747    | 0.0006828      | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| X2: Brand Image                                     | 0.0103197   | 0.0018139      | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| X3: Brand Extension                                 | -0.2251725  | 0.637603       | 0.727                             |
| X4: Brand Marketing                                 | 0.100878    | 0.0370039      | 0.011                             |
| _cons Constant                                      | -90.57168   | 26.83251       | 0.002                             |

Therefore, the empirical results show that brand positioning, brand image, and brand marketing have significant positive effects on consumer purchase intention.

### 4.2.3.4 Relationship between Brand Management and Its Four Components - Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, and Brand Marketing

First, the results are as follows:

Table 4-2-3-4-1

| Y: Brand Management   | Coefficient | Standard Error | P-value (95% CI)                  |
|-----------------------|-------------|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| X1: Brand Positioning | 0.0096399   | 0.0041344      | 0.028                             |
| X2: Brand Image       | 0.0122322   | 0.0117586      | 0.308                             |
| X3: Brand Extension   | -1.387961   | 4.128248       | 0.739                             |
| X4: Brand Marketing   | 3.488845    | 0.2347026      | 0.000 (three zeros after decimal) |
| _cons Constant        | -568.0592   | 162.2318       | 0.002                             |

Therefore, the empirical results show that brand positioning and brand marketing have significant positive effects on brand management. Brand marketing has the strongest effect on brand management: for every one-unit increase, the brand management score increases by 3.488845 units.

Further explanation: this study examines linear correlations among variables. Therefore,

$p > 0.05$  indicates that no linear correlation is found, but it does not demonstrate that no relationship exists at all. Two possibilities remain: (1) the variables may have a nonlinear relationship; or (2) the variables may be unrelated.

### 4.3 Model Evaluation and Discussion of Hypothesis-Testing Results

#### 4.3.1 Evaluation of the Stata Regression Model

The advantages of Stata regression analysis are as follows. First, the empirical operation is easy and convenient in terms of data input, command execution, and variable management. Second, the data output is clear and complete because the program directly generates result tables. Third, the analytical process is straightforward, as the analysis mainly focuses on p-values and coefficients.

However, this model also has some shortcomings that should not be ignored. First, it analyzes only linear relationships among variables and neglects possible nonlinear relationships, making the inference from the results incomplete. Second, no deeper analysis is conducted, such as testing R-squared values.

Overall, the model has both advantages and disadvantages and leaves room for subsequent improvement.

#### 4.3.2 Results and Discussion of Hypothesis Testing

##### 4.3.2.1 Results of Hypothesis Testing

The above analyses test the original hypotheses as follows:

Table 4-3-1 Hypothesis-Testing Results

| Relationship                                     | Hypothesis                                                     | Test Result                       |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Brand Management and Consumer Perception         | H1: Brand management is unrelated to consumer perception       | Rejected                          |
|                                                  | H2: Brand positioning is unrelated to consumer perception      | Rejected                          |
| Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, | H3: Brand image is unrelated to consumer perception            | Supported; no linear relationship |
| Brand Marketing, and Consumer Perception         | H4: Brand extension is unrelated to consumer perception        | Supported; no linear relationship |
|                                                  | H5: Brand marketing is unrelated to consumer perception        | Rejected                          |
| Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, | H6: Brand positioning is unrelated to consumer brand awareness | Rejected                          |

|                                                                                                   |                                                                    |                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Awareness                                                     | H7: Brand image is unrelated to consumer brand awareness           | Supported; no linear relationship                                      |
|                                                                                                   | H8: Brand extension is unrelated to consumer brand awareness       | Supported; no linear relationship                                      |
|                                                                                                   | H9: Brand marketing is unrelated to consumer brand awareness       | Rejected                                                               |
|                                                                                                   | H10: Brand positioning is unrelated to consumer brand attitude     | Supported; no linear relationship                                      |
| Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Brand Attitude     | H11: Brand image is unrelated to consumer brand attitude           | Rejected                                                               |
|                                                                                                   | H12: Brand extension is unrelated to consumer brand attitude       | Supported; no linear relationship                                      |
|                                                                                                   | H13: Brand marketing is unrelated to consumer brand attitude       | Supported; no linear relationship                                      |
|                                                                                                   | H14: Brand positioning is unrelated to consumer purchase intention | Rejected                                                               |
| Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Consumer Purchase Intention | H15: Brand image is unrelated to consumer purchase intention       | Rejected                                                               |
|                                                                                                   | H16: Brand extension is unrelated to consumer purchase intention   | Supported; no linear relationship                                      |
|                                                                                                   | H17: Brand marketing is unrelated to consumer purchase intention   | Rejected                                                               |
|                                                                                                   | H18: Brand positioning is unrelated to brand management            | Rejected                                                               |
|                                                                                                   | H19: Brand image is unrelated to brand management                  | Supported; no linear relationship, but a nonlinear relationship exists |
| Brand Positioning, Brand Image, Brand Extension, Brand Marketing, and Brand Management            | H20: Brand extension is unrelated to brand management              | Supported; no linear relationship, but a nonlinear relationship exists |
|                                                                                                   | H21: Brand marketing is unrelated to brand management              | Rejected                                                               |

#### 4.3.2.2 Explanation and Discussion

##### 1) Brand Management

The empirical results demonstrate that brand management has a significant effect on consumer perception, which is consistent with the large number of research hypotheses proposed by scholars in this field. The practical implication for business is that brands and numerous small and medium-sized enterprises can implement brand management strategies to improve awareness of and preference for their products and services in consumer markets.

The specific effects of the components of brand management are explained by category below:

## **2) Brand Positioning**

Brand positioning affects consumer brand recognition, consumer purchase intention, and overall consumer perception, but it has no significant relationship with consumer brand attitude.

Explanation:

Because brand positioning initially determines a brand's target market and consumer segment, and because consumers rely heavily on externally provided descriptive information when they first encounter a brand, consumer brand recognition largely comes from the brand's own positioning descriptions. At this stage, consumers passively receive a relatively large amount of information;

As consumers gradually become familiar with the brand, they enter the second stage of the brand-consumer relationship. At this stage, consumers' attitudes toward the brand are affected by multiple factors such as purchase experience, personal understanding, and values, so the role of brand positioning becomes smaller;

When consumers enter the third stage and consider whether to purchase the brand, the brand's positioning again becomes more prominent because the brand serves as a social identifier and conveys class-related signals [40], giving consumers a sense of identity within a particular group.

## **3) Brand Image**

Brand image affects consumer brand attitude and consumer purchase intention, but it has no significant relationship with consumer brand recognition.

Explanation:

After the initial and relatively shallow stage of brand recognition, consumers gradually form attitudes toward the brand. The influence of brand image on brand attitude comes from both external VI corporate visual design and internal corporate and brand image, with the latter having a stronger effect. Corporate and brand image include MI conceptual identity design, namely the brand's mission, vision, and values. By portraying its own philosophy, the brand communicates responsibility and commitment to building a better future and thereby

attracts customers with similar values and lifestyles. On the other hand, BI behavioral identity also plays an increasingly important role today. A brand's actions in management and operations, social responsibility, environmental protection, and other areas can establish a positive image that shows concern for disadvantaged groups, wealth inequality, and global environmental crises. Such actions include using biodegradable packaging, reducing global carbon emissions, and making voluntary donations.

At the purchasing stage, VI brand visual factors exert a relatively strong influence. Because modern consumers seek differentiation and prefer clothing that highlights individuality and expresses personality, brands that perform well in logo colors, design, tailoring, and related visual elements are more likely to increase consumers' purchase inclination. Consumers are also more likely to purchase brands whose values align with their own and increasingly consider brands' social responsibility [41]. For example, if a brand states that it will donate a portion of each sale to food security for children in Africa, consumers are more likely to prefer that brand than a brand without such a commitment.

Brand image has no significant relationship with consumer brand recognition, mainly because consumers are in a low-involvement state at this stage and engage in little active information search. They therefore receive more superficial information such as logos and colors. At the same time, intense competition and product homogeneity in the apparel industry make it difficult for brands to leave a distinctive impression on consumers. For example, among the sampled brands in this study, 63.33% use black as a primary logo color, resulting in relatively weak differentiation.

#### **4) Brand Extension**

Brand extension has no significant correlation with consumer brand recognition, brand attitude, purchase intention, or overall consumer perception.

Explanation:

It is reasonable that brand extension does not affect consumer perception.

First, brand extension includes the number of product categories. Although a large number of categories indicates a broad brand product line, this does not necessarily relate to consumer perception. By contrast, concentrating categories in several specific areas can demonstrate specialization by an apparel brand and communicate perceptions of "quality" and

“commitment.” For example, LEE and WRANGLER focus on denim products and have also achieved broad recognition among consumers.

Second, brand extension includes the number of brand stores. Although a large number of stores reflects a company’s financial capacity, it does not accurately reflect consumer perception. Consumers focus more on online and offline consumption experiences, including store atmosphere, service attitude, and after-sales service.

Third, brand extension includes brand internationalization. Multinational brands in the previous century did indeed enjoy relatively high global awareness. However, with the development of internet technology and social-media communication in recent years, brands can attract global consumer attention, generate substantial discussion, and even stimulate international purchasing on behalf of consumers even when they have relatively few overseas stores.

Finally, brand extension also includes the number of brand collaborations. The data show that although the new promotional method of “brand collaboration” achieved considerable success during the 2010s, many brands subsequently imitated this approach, greatly reducing consumer excitement and perception. Brand collaboration activities have declined particularly since the COVID-19 pandemic. For example, Vans, described as a “pioneer of brand collaborations,” had 125 collaborations in 2018 and 116 in 2019, but the number fell to only 78 in 2020.

## **5) Brand Marketing**

Brand marketing is significantly correlated with consumer brand recognition, purchase intention, and overall consumer perception, and it is also the most effective factor for improving brand management performance.

Explanation:

Brand marketing is mainly divided into advertising marketing, social-media marketing, and experiential marketing.

First, in terms of consumer brand recognition, advertising has a relatively strong effect. Compared with traditional print advertising, brands are now more skilled at placing online video advertisements. On the one hand, because such advertisements are inserted before and during media content and television programs, consumers are highly exposed to them and

spend more time viewing them, resulting in stronger effects. On the other hand, promotional videos for fashion and apparel brands are highly creative. They generally do not simply display and sell products but instead tell brand stories and express brand spirit and brand attitudes, with high-quality editing and music production. Consumers are therefore willing to watch them. Advertising consequently plays an important role in forming consumer brand recognition for new brands.

Second, with respect to consumer purchase intention, social media and experiential marketing have significant effects. First, on social media, key opinion leaders greatly influence the purchase decisions of their followers. Key opinion leaders are people with large online audiences and therefore strong social influence, including celebrities, influencers, and other well-known individuals. Brands generally cooperate with such people to promote products, and the resulting increases in traffic and sales cannot be ignored. Second, experiential marketing mainly concerns consumers' experiences in physical brand stores. Consumers' combined perceptions of the store environment, shopping atmosphere, employee attitudes, and their own emotions constitute a unique brand experience and thereby promote in-store consumption.

Finally, brand marketing is the most effective factor for improving brand management performance because, compared with other strategies, it has the lowest input-output ratio in terms of required investment for generated returns. In an era in which marketing activities are largely conducted online, relatively low investment can generate substantial brand outcomes. For example, a brand can post an update on Facebook at almost zero cost and receive millions of consumer likes and comments, or a single celebrity endorsement can cause sales to increase several-fold.

## 5 Research Limitations

This study still has the following limitations, which may be improved in future research:

First, the sample size is relatively small. Although it satisfies the statistical requirements for confidence level and confidence interval, a small sample size still increases the probability of error.

Second, the models have room for improvement. First, the Stata regression analysis selected in this study examines only linear correlations among variables and does not discuss nonlinear relationships, making the analysis incomplete. Second, although the Interbrand model used to quantify brand management and the HIROSE model used to quantify consumer perception are highly authoritative in industry, each construct is determined using only one model. Future research could refer to multiple models and make corresponding adjustments.

Third, there is extensive data analysis but relatively few empirical examples. Although the conclusion and discussion section lists and analyzes brand management strategies of multiple brands, the number of cases remains small relative to the total number of brands.

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## Appendix

### A. Statista Global Consumer Survey 2021 (Excerpt)



**Statista Global Consumer Survey 2021**

**Questionnaire - International Version (English)**

February 2021

Method: Online Survey  
 Region: Global  
 Number of countries/territories: 56 (21 extended & 35 basic countries/territories)  
 Respondents: 18-64 years old residential online population

**Demographics**

*Introduction (text display, basic questionnaire)*

**Thank you for your interest in this survey! By taking part in the survey you agree to our privacy policies, which include the anonymous processing of your data and their use and publication for commercial and scientific purposes. Please feel free to contact our data protection officer: [dataprotection@statista.com](mailto:dataprotection@statista.com) and check [www.statista.com/dataprotection](http://www.statista.com/dataprotection) for further information regarding our rules on deleting data, transferring data or working with third parties regarding your data.**

*Age (open question, basic questionnaire)*

**How old are you?**  
 - [input] years

*Gender (single pick, basic questionnaire)*

**What is your gender?**  
 - Female  
 - Male

*Region (detailed) - Algeria (single pick, basic questionnaire)*

**Where do you currently live?**  
 [regional list]

*Internet usage by device (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**Which of these devices do you regularly use with an internet connection?**

- Desktop PC
- Laptop with touch screen
- Regular laptop (without touch screen)
- Streaming device (e.g. Apple TV, Chromecast)
- Smartphone
- Smart TV
- Tablet
- Smartwatch
- Smart speakers (e.g. Amazon Echo)
- Gaming console (e.g. PS4, Xbox)
- None of the above (exclusive)

**Health**

*Attitudes towards healthcare (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

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## Finance

*Attitudes towards personal finances (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about finance: Which of these statements apply to you?**

- Managing my personal financial affairs is too complicated for me
- I could imagine dealing with my financial transactions exclusively online
- I could imagine dealing with my financial transactions exclusively via my smartphone
- I could imagine getting all my financial services from an internet company like Google or Apple
- I'm worried about my financial future
- I'm well informed about my personal financial situation
- I could save a lot of money if I took advice by a finance expert (e.g. on taxes, bank and insurance issues)
- If the service is good, I'm happy to pay for account administration and transactions
- None of the above (exclusive)

*Financial product usage (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**Which of these financial products and investments do you currently use / own?**

- Equity investment (stocks / investment funds)
- Construction loan
- Precious metals (e.g. gold)
- Certificate of deposit (time deposit) [hidden item]
- Real estate
- Cryptocurrency (e.g. Bitcoin)
- Overnight deposit [hidden item]
- Insurance with an investment character (e.g. life insurance)
- Checking account
- Loan
- Credit card
- Other capital investment
- Savings account (short / long term)
- Don't know (exclusive)
- I do not use / own any financial products or investments (exclusive)

## Insurance

*Attitudes towards insurances (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about insurances: Which of these statements apply to you?**

- Managing my personal insurances is too complicated for me
- I could imagine managing my insurances exclusively online
- I could imagine getting all my insurances from an internet company like Google or Apple
- I could imagine consulting a algorithm-based digital program (RoboAdvisor) for advice on insurances
- I'm worried that I might not have the right kind of insurances
- I'm well informed about my personal insurances
- I could benefit if I took advice by an insurance expert (e.g. on premiums, coverage)

## Consumer Electronics

*Attitudes towards consumer electronics (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about consumer electronics (e.g. TVs, laptops, smartphones): Which of the following statements apply to you?**

- I would love to control my home via smartphone or voice
- I could not live without my smartphone
- Electronics are a status symbol for me
- I want the best audio and cinematic experience from all my devices
- I buy new electronics, even when my old model still works
- None of the above (exclusive)

*Consumer electronics ownership (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**Which of the following electronic devices does your household own?**

- TV

## Internet & Devices

*Attitudes towards the internet (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about the internet: Which of the following statements apply to you?**

- It is important to me to have mobile internet access in any place at any time
- I could no longer imagine my everyday life without the internet
- I'm concerned that my data are being misused on the internet
- I actively do something for the protection of my data
- Saving sensitive data online is too insecure for me
- I'm well protected against viruses and data abuse
- There is a good mobile network coverage in my area (e.g. data speed, call stability)
- Having access to the latest cellular network technology (5G) is important to me
- None of the above (exclusive)

*Internet access by type (single pick, basic questionnaire)*

**How do you mainly access the internet at home?**

- Analog line (dial-up)
- ISDN
- Broadband (DSL, cable, etc.)
- Mobile connection via smartphone / tablet
- UMTS / GPRS / LTE router
- Satellite access
- The neighbor's / landlord's wireless connection
- Other connection technology
- Don't know
- I don't have internet access at home

## eCommerce & Retail

*Attitudes towards shopping (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about shopping: Which of these statements do you agree with?**

- Apparel and footwear have to be, above all, comfortable and practical
- I always shop at the same stores
- Dressing well is very important for me
- When strolling through stores, I tend to buy items spontaneously
- When shopping, I look out for special offers
- I prefer to purchase goods from various sellers through the same online shop (market place)
- None of the above (exclusive)

*Interest in product categories (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**Which of these products and services are you interested in?**

- Bags & accessories
- Clothing
- Shoes
- Consumer electronics (e.g. TV, smartphones)
- Household appliances
- Drugstore & health products

## Media & Digital Media

*Attitudes towards digital media (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about music, movies and games: Which of these statements do you agree with?**

- I use alternative websites and apps to watch paid content for free
- It is important to me to get the best image and sound quality
- I want to access my music / movies on all my devices (TV, smartphone, tablet, etc.)
- I prefer to own hard copies of films, books or music (e.g. DVD, CD, vinyl)
- I prefer digital content as it is easier to manage

## Marketing & Social Media

*Attitudes towards online advertising (multi pick, basic questionnaire)*

**The following questions are about online advertising: Which of these statements do you agree with?**

- It annoys me when I receive online ads based on my search history
- I don't mind advertising if I get free content in return
- I have bought products because celebrities or influencers advertised them
- I use ad blockers when browsing the internet
- I am often annoyed by advertising on the internet
- I don't mind when companies use my personal data for advertising
- None of the above (exclusive)

*Sources of inspiration for new products (multi pick, extended questionnaire)*

**How do you usually find out about new interesting products?**

- Blogs and podcasts
- Online forums
- Question and answer websites and apps
- Friends and acquaintances
- Coupon and deal websites and apps
- In the store
- Customer reviews
- Online stores
- Price comparison websites
- Celebrities
- Social media websites and apps
- Search engines (e.g. Google)
- Video websites and apps (e.g. YouTube)
- Brand websites and apps
- Magazine and newspaper websites and apps
- Advertisements
- Magazines and newspapers
- None of the above (exclusive)

## Demographics

*Education (international comparison) (single pick, basic questionnaire)*

**What is the highest level of education you have completed?**

- No formal education
- Basic education / primary school
- Secondary education (no permission to go to university)
- Further education (permission to go to university)
- Technical / vocational education
- Bachelor degree or equivalent
- Master degree or equivalent
- Doctoral degree or equivalent

*Employment status (single pick, basic questionnaire)*

**Which of the following categories best describes your current employment status?**

- Student (school)
- Trainee / apprentice
- Student (university)
- Full-time employed
- Part-time employed
- Self-employed / freelancer
- Maternal leave, parental leave
- Retired
- Unemployed
- Other

## **B. Excel Sheets**

Attached in the Thesis Folder.

- 1.2\_Scale.xlsx
- 1.3\_Hirose\_Consumer\_Perception\_Calculation.xlsx
- 1.4\_Interbrand\_Brand\_Value\_Calculation.xlsx
- 2.1\_Independent\_Variable\_Coding\_Rules.xlsx
- 3.1\_Total\_Brand\_Value\_Total\_Consumer\_Perception.xlsx
- 3.2\_Brand\_Management\_Dimensions\_Total\_Consumer\_Perception.xlsx
- 3.3.1\_Brand\_Management\_Dimensions\_Brand\_Awareness.xlsx
- 3.3.2\_Brand\_Management\_Dimensions\_Loyalty.xlsx
- 3.3.3\_Brand\_Management\_Dimensions\_Purchase\_Intention.xlsx
- 3.4\_Brand\_Management\_Dimensions\_Total\_Brand\_Value.xlsx

## **C. Stata Modeling Codes and Outputs**

Attached in the Thesis Folder

Brand\_Management.html (Codes, markups, and outputs display)

Dataset Inputs:

- 3.1\_English.dta
- 3.2\_English.dta
- 3.3.1\_English.dta
- 3.3.2\_English.dta
- 3.3.3\_English.dta
- 3.4\_English.dta